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Official Records

6th plenary meeting
Wednesday, 24 September 2025, 9 a.m.
New York

President: Ms. Baerbock ..... (Germany)

In the absence of the President, Ms. Wagner (Democratic Republic of the Congo), Vice-President, took the Chair.

The meeting was called to order at 9.05 a.m.

Address by His Majesty Don Felipe VI, King of the Kingdom of Spain

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): The Assembly will now hear an address by His Majesty Don Felipe VI, King of Spain.

His Majesty Don Felipe VI, King of Spain, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Majesty Don Felipe VI, King of Spain, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

King Felipe (*spoke in Spanish*): I stand before the representatives of the Member States of the United Nations today, in the year that marks the eightieth anniversary of the Organization's founding. It is an opportune moment to reflect on the present, past and future of this universal Organization and its contribution to peace, stability and development in these extremely complex times.

Ours is a fast-paced and unrestrained world, one which too often places us on the brink of disaster. There is no shortage of voices that proclaim the end of multilateralism and the obsolescence and ineffectiveness of the United Nations. We are told that this is the result of replacing dialogue and cooperation with competition, rivalry and extreme tensions. We hear that this is not the world we are headed towards, but rather the world in which we are already immersed.

Faced with this sense of collapse, we must acknowledge that times have clearly changed, and we must adapt, even anticipate, without taking refuge in idealism, complacency or shortsightedness. It is precisely in these moments of uncertainty that

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we must understand the key issues of our time, so as not to repeat past mistakes and get caught in a downward spiral of no return.

We are aided in this by memory, which is the most valuable tool that any generation possesses to confront its challenges. The memory of the twentieth century challenges us each time that we gather in this General Assembly. It reminds us why this house of the international community was created, under which circumstances it was born, and which dark chapters of history it sought to close definitively.

It is worth repeating in this Hall the opening words of the Preamble to the Charter of the United Nations, which begins with "We the peoples of the United Nations determined to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war".

Which of the great ideals enshrined therein — peace, dignity, justice, progress — has ceased to be relevant or to represent an urgent ethical imperative? On which of these paths have we made sufficient progress over these eight decades to be able to consider the course of multilateralism and cooperation complete? The greatest proof that the United Nations remains not only useful, but also indispensable and irreplaceable lies in the silence in the face of these questions.

To believe in the United Nations is to believe firmly in the universality of the principles and values enshrined in its Charter and in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights. It is to resist the temptation to modulate them with particularism, with relativism and with exceptions, because the dignity of the human being is non-negotiable.

To believe in the United Nations is also to believe in a rules-based world. Rules give rise to behaviours to which the vast majority of international actors adhere. Even when they are breached or violated, they provide a basis for asserting and enforcing them. Rules are the voice of reason applied to international relations, the best defence we have against the rule of might makes right. A world without rules is uncharted territory; a time without rules is a return to the Dark Ages.

The path proposed by the Charter of the United Nations is fraught with obstacles, and we will never reach the end. That is why the example of so many people committed to its values and principles is so valuable — people working in extreme conditions, at risk of their freedom, physical safety or even their lives, in a world ravaged by conflict in too many regions.

We are seeing this on the European continent, in Ukraine, with the war unleashed by the Russian Federation's unprovoked and unjustifiable aggression, in violation of Ukraine's sovereignty and territorial integrity. Peace in Europe will not be possible without justice and accountability. Spain will continue to support all efforts aimed at achieving a just and lasting peace, grounded in the principles of international law, respect for human rights and accountability.

We see it also, in all of its starkness, in the Middle East, in Palestine and in the Gaza Strip. We cannot remain silent or look the other way in the face of the devastation and the bombings of hospitals, schools and places of refuge; in the face of so many deaths among the civilian population; and in the face of famine and the forced displacement of hundreds of thousands of people — and to what end? These are abhorrent acts that are the antithesis of everything this forum represents. They offend the human conscience and shame the entire international community.

Spain is deeply proud of its Sephardic roots. When we speak to the people of Israel, we are speaking to a people of brothers and sisters, a people who, when they return to Spain — to Córdoba, Toledo, Seville, Barcelona and many other places — they are returning home. This was the guiding principle behind the 2015 law that, with broad consensus, granted Spanish nationality to the descendants of Sephardic Jews originating in Spain. That is why it pains us so much, why we struggle so much to understand what

the Israeli Government is doing in the Gaza Strip. That is why we cry out, implore and demand: stop this massacre now. No more deaths in the name of such a wise and ancient people, who have suffered so much throughout history.

Let us be clear: we unequivocally condemn the despicable terrorism of Hamas and especially the brutal massacre of 7 October 2023 against the Israeli population, and we recognize Israel's right to defend itself. But with equal firmness, we demand that the Israeli Government uphold international humanitarian law without reservation throughout Gaza and the West Bank. We demand the arrival, without delay of humanitarian aid; a ceasefire with guarantees; and the immediate release of all the hostages still held so cruelly by Hamas.

The international community must assume its responsibility to bring about, as soon as possible, a viable solution that contemplates the existence of two States. The recognition of the State of Palestine by a growing number of members of our Organization, and Spain's recognition of same in May 2024, should help to achieve a just and lasting regional peace, based on the implementation of United Nations resolutions and on the universal recognition of the State of Israel.

As we know, many conflicts are caused by and a consequence of the lack of resources, the fragility of States and inequalities. The gap separating us from the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals set out in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development remains vast, and the current funding shortfall for sustainable development exceeds $4 trillion annually.

The call for efficiency and the optimization of resources, made at the Fourth International Conference on Financing for Development, held recently in Seville, must continue. For that reason, Spain, in line with the Sevilla Commitment, adopted by consensus, has launched the Seville Plan to Support Multilateralism. We have increased our contribution to international development funds and reaffirmed our commitment to the defence of human rights, gender equality and the green transition, which are central and distinctive elements of our foreign policy.

I will briefly address each of those three areas.

First, on human rights, as of 2025, Spain is a member of the Human Rights Council, which will allow us to continue working on causes such as the fight against racism; the abolition of the death penalty; and the promotion of economic, social and cultural rights; as well as to persist in the fight against all forms of discrimination.

This is because we are proponents of pluralistic, open societies where all citizens participate. We are concerned about the erosion of democracies, the growing disaffection we observe towards values essential for democratic coexistence. In these confusing times, which test our capacity for dialogue, we must remain most faithful to these values.

In line with these principles, we believe that immigration, when properly managed, is a vector of mutual development for societies of origin, transit and destination, and that the human rights of migrants must therefore be the primary reference point for our actions. That is why we wholeheartedly support the implementation of the Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration and the Global Compact on Refugees.

Secondly, on gender equality, 2025 marks the thirtieth anniversary of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, which presents a new opportunity to renew our commitment to genuine and effective equality. This is not only a step forward in human rights, but above all a matter of justice. Spain aspires to remain a global leader in issues such as championing sexual and reproductive rights, combating sexual and gender-based violence and promoting greater participation of women in leadership positions and decision-making processes.

Thirdly, on the environment, the triple planetary crisis we are facing — climate change, pollution and biodiversity loss — demands stronger governance and sufficient resources to accelerate a just energy transition, enabling us to triple renewable energy capacity, double energy efficiency and to continue decarbonizing our economies. These are ambitious yet crucial objectives. Therefore, there is no room for doubt.

Spain calls for consensus and ambition ahead of the upcoming thirtieth session of the Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, which will bring us together in Brazil in November. There are other significant challenges, such as managing the impact of the Copernican revolution in artificial intelligence, which can accelerate progress on the 2030 Agenda if we guide it towards a fair and equitable digital transformation. In the area of health, whose global dimension became tragically evident in the recent coronavirus disease pandemic, we celebrate the consensus reached on the World Health Organization Pandemic Agreement, which reinforces the World Health Organization's central role in the global health architecture.

Spain's foreign policy is underpinned by three fundamental axes, due to its geographical position, history and conviction: Africa and the Mediterranean, the Americas and the Atlantic, and Europe. I would like to make a few remarks regarding those three areas.

Spain is well aware that Africa constitutes a global strategic interest of paramount importance. The present is marked, in certain countries, by structural deficiencies and some atrocious wars and conflicts, which receive little attention compared with others already mentioned. I am referring to the numerous peacekeeping operations in the region, to which my country contributes decisively. This is the case in Western Sahara, where Spain will continue to support the Personal Envoy of the Secretary-General to reach an acceptable solution in accordance with United Nations norms and frameworks.

The future of Africa will be shaped by a young, dynamic and proactive population that is increasingly active in global affairs. This is the future we must support. That is why Spain has adopted the Spain-Africa Strategy 2025–2028. We would like to develop a partnership based on concrete actions and shared interests, one that also serves to promote the vibrant African multilateralism embodied by the African Union and other subregional organizations.

In strictly bilateral terms, I cannot overlook the special neighbourly and cooperative relationship that unites us with the Kingdom of Morocco, one which we have revitalized in recent years to the benefit of our peoples.

For Spain, Latin America and the Caribbean represent a community of sister nations, an irreplaceable part of an identity strengthened by a shared heritage — the Spanish language, spoken by 600 million speakers worldwide. Our country holds the Pro Tempore Secretariat of the Ibero-American Community of Nations until the end of 2026, and Madrid will host the next Ibero-American Summit. We will continue to support the European Union's actions in the region, which this year will culminate in the summit between the Community of Latin American and Caribbean States and the European Union, to be held in Colombia in November.

The European Union represents one of the highest achievements of harmony and a model for multilateralism. In these times, its voice is more necessary than ever, and that is why we are committed to an increasingly effective, cohesive European Union, capable of guaranteeing its security and competitiveness in the global economy.

It is important to recall that on 11 June a definitive political agreement was announced relating to the key aspects of the future agreement between the European Union and the United Kingdom. This was a historic agreement that respects Spain's position regarding sovereignty and jurisdiction over Gibraltar, which will bring

confidence, legal certainty and stability to the lives of the people of the Campo de Gibraltar and Gibraltar itself.

I began by speaking about the past and present of the United Nations, and I will dedicate my final remarks to its future. At this time of severe budgetary constraints, I appeal to the commitment of all the Member States to the Organization. I encourage all of its staff, led by the Secretary-General, to persist in their enormous efforts to be efficient and effective, prioritizing those areas whose neglect would represent an unacceptable breach of the ethical standards that must always govern their work. We continue to believe in the need to develop reform initiatives, and for this endeavour we offer our capacity for dialogue and consensus-building, as well as our firm multilateral conviction.

On the occasion of this eightieth anniversary, which coincides with the seventieth anniversary of Spain's accession, I wish to renew my country's recognition of all the men and women working at the United Nations. They are the custodians of the memory of the twentieth century, and the guarantors of the hopes placed in the twenty-first century. It is now, when more questions arise than ever before regarding multilateralism and cooperation, that we need them the most.

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the King of Spain for the statement he has just made.

His Majesty Don Felipe VI, King of Spain, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Volodymyr Zelenskyy, President of Ukraine

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): The Assembly will now hear an address by His Excellency Volodymyr Zelenskyy, President of Ukraine.

Mr. Volodymyr Zelenskyy, President of Ukraine, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Volodymyr Zelenskyy, President of Ukraine, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Zelenskyy: Dear leaders, friends and all those who can become our friends: you want safety and peace just as much as we do. Yet today, no one but ourselves can guarantee security. Only strong alliances, only strong partners and only our own weapons can do so.

The twenty-first century is not much different from the past. If a nation wants peace, it still has to work with weapons. It is sick, but that is the reality. It is not international law and not cooperation, but rather weapons that decide who survives.

Members know perfectly well that international law does not work fully unless you have powerful friends who are truly willing to stand up for it. And even that does not work without weapons. It is terrible, but without them, things would be even worse. There are no security guarantees except friends and weapons.

No Ukrainian chose this reality. Knowing our people, they would have chosen a different priority. Ukrainians are a peaceful people, but they want to live freely, in their own independent country. That is why we invest in defence. For many nations, there is simply no other way.

Nations can speak about their pain from stages such as this one, but even during bloodshed there is not a single international institution that can truly stop it. That is how weak such institutions have become.

What can the Sudan or Somalia or Palestine or any other people living through war really expect from the United Nations or the global system? For decades, there have been only statements and more statements. Even with everything that has happened in Gaza, there remains no way out. Even now, Syria — after all the changes — still has to appeal to the world to ease the sanctions that are choking its economy. It has to ask and wait. Syria deserves stronger support from the international community.

As Russia's war against my country continues, people are still dying every week. Yet, there is no ceasefire because the Russia refuses. Russia abducted thousands of Ukrainian children. We have brought some of them back. I thank everyone who has helped. But how long will it take to bring all of them home? Childhood slips away faster than adults are able to help.

Look at Israel. Nearly two years have passed, and hostages still have not been freed. They must be freed. But even that still has not happened.

For years, there have been no real answers to other threats either, including the threats of chemical weapons and famine used as a weapon.

In 2024, at the Assembly, I warned the world about the risk of radiation disasters, especially owing to the Russian's occupation of our Zaporizhzhia nuclear power plant, the biggest in Europe (see A/79/PV.9). But nothing has changed. Yesterday there was a blackout at the plant again. And Russia has not stopped shelling, even in areas near a nuclear facility. Because the international institutions are too weak, this madness continues.

Even being part of a long-standing military alliance does not automatically mean you are safe. Just recently, 19 simple Russian drones violated Polish airspace. Only four were shot down. Luckily, they were not Shaheds or worse, otherwise the results would have been horrific.

Estonia had to call a Security Council meeting, for the first time in history, because Russian fighter jets deliberately entered its airspace (see S/PV.10002).

The Republic of Moldova is defending itself again from the Russia's interference. We are helping the Republic of Moldova. Russia is trying to do to the Republic of Moldova what the Islamic Republic of Iran once did to Lebanon. The global response is again not enough. We have already lost Georgia in Europe. Human rights and the European nature of the State system are only shrinking there. Georgia is dependent on Russia.

For many years, Belarus has also been moving towards dependence on Russia. Europe cannot afford to lose Moldova too.

It is important to remember how the world once ignored the need to help Georgia after Russia's attack and how the moment was missed with Belarus. Moldova must not be lost. For Europe, supporting the Republic of Moldova's stability is not costly, but failing to do so would come at a much higher price. That is why the European Union needs to help the Republic of Moldova now with funding and energy support, not just words or political gestures.

We must not forget about protecting the rights of people and the rights of nations in regions where these rights are under threat. The Charter of the United Nations and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights must apply everywhere.

The Taliban in Afghanistan dragged a whole country back into the dark ages. Cartels in some Latin American countries are more powerful than their governments. This is all about the collapse of international law and the weakness of international institutions. And so, it is about the rise of weapons. Weapons decide who survives.

Yesterday, President Trump stood here, in this Hall. God saved him from a murder attempt during the campaign. A shot was fired from a rifle, and just a fraction of an inch saved his life. Just days before, the President, along with hundreds of thousands of Americans, honoured the memory of Charlie Kirk. Sadly, his life was cut short by a bullet — another example of violence carried out with a rifle.

We also mourn the Ukrainian woman, Iryna Zarutska, who was brutally killed with a knife here in America, the very country in which she was seeking refuge from Russia's war.

Almost every day, when we open the news, we see headlines about violent attacks happening all around the world. Most of it is done with weapons, which people are already used to. But weapons are evolving faster than our ability to defend ourselves.

Now, there are tens of thousands of people who know how to professionally kill using drones. Stopping that kind of attack is harder than stopping any gun, knife or bomb. This is what the Russian Federation has brought with its war. It used to be that only the strongest countries could use drones, because they were expensive and complex. Now, even simple drones can fly thousands of kilometres. War technology does not care about geography anymore; it is now reshaping it. Just recently, airports in Europe had to shut down because of drones. Authorities could not even say what kind of drones they were, who sent them or where they were sent from. Last week, North Korea announced the test of a tactical strike drone. That means even countries with limited resources can now build weapons that are dangerous to their neighbours.

Ukraine, and nations like Saudi Arabia, know all too well how dangerous Iranian attack drones are. But what happens when all the types of drones become available even to small terrorist groups or cartels? The world moves too slowly to protect itself, and weapons move fast.

Now companies are already working on drones that can shoot down other drones. It is only a matter of time, and not much, before drones are fighting drones, attacking critical infrastructure and targeting people, all by themselves, fully autonomous and no human involved, except the few who control artificial intelligence (AI) systems.

We are now living through the most destructive arms race in human history, because this time, it includes artificial intelligence. If there are no real security guarantees, except friends and weapons, and if the world cannot respond even to old threats, and if there is no strong platform for international security, will there be any place left on Earth that is still safe for people?

We need global rules now for how AI can be used in weapons. This is just as urgent as preventing the spread of nuclear weapons.

We need to restore international cooperation, real working cooperation, for peace and security. A few years from now might already be too late. Ten years ago, war looked different. No one imagined that cheap drones could create "dead zones", areas stretching for dozens of kilometres where nothing moves, no vehicles, no life. People used to imagine only a nuclear strike, now it is drone reality. Mass-produced, simple drones and without AI yet.

Ukraine does not have the big, fat missiles dictators love to show off in parades. But we do have drones that can fly up to 2,000–3,000 kilometres. We had no choice but to build them to protect our right to life.

Control over the sea used to depend on having a big navy. Ukraine does not have a big fleet, but we succeeded in the Black Sea. We pushed what is left of the Russian navy into remote bays. We did it with sea drones. That is how we protect our ports and maritime trade routes, because Russia has left us no other choice.

Our Operation Spider Web — when cheap drones destroyed or damaged dozens of expensive Russian strategic bombers — became a real example for special forces around the world of what new weapons can do to old systems. These very Russian bombers attacked our cities.

None of this would have happened if Putin had not started this full-scale aggression, full-scale war. Every year that this war goes on, weapons become even more deadly. And Russia alone deserves to be blamed for this.

To protect lives, Ukraine builds underground schools and underground hospitals. To protect lives, we have to spend more on protecting power stations from drone and missile attacks than on building sports facilities or cultural infrastructure. Ukrainian farmers are learning how to protect their equipment from Russia's first-person view drone strikes, and for them that challenge is far greater than climate change.

The Russia's war has put us in this situation, but do Member States have protection against similar threats? The facts are simple: stopping this war now, and with it the global arms race, is cheaper than building underground kindergartens or massive bunkers for critical infrastructure later. Stopping Putin now is cheaper than trying to protect every port and every ship from terrorists with sea drones. Stopping the Russia now is cheaper than wondering who will be the first to create a simple drone carrying a nuclear warhead.

Therefore, we must use everything we have, together, to force the aggressor to stop. Only then do we have a real chance that this arms race will not end in catastrophe for all of us. If it takes weapons to do it, if it takes pressure on Russia – then that must be done, and it must be done now. Otherwise, Putin will continue to push the war further, expanding its scope and intensity.

We told Member States before: Ukraine is only the first. Now, Russian drones are already flying across Europe. Russian operations are already spreading across countries. Putin wants to continue this war by expanding it. No one can feel safe right now.

First, we are now building a new security architecture for ourselves. More than 30 countries are already part of our coalition. We are strengthening the army, launching joint weapons production with partners and defining financial commitments for defence in a way that could become a security model for any other nation. If security guarantees work for Ukraine — something more than just friends and weapons — it will mean that people were able to make national security not a privilege for a few nations, but a right for everyone.

Secondly, we are ready to make our modern weapons become Member States' modern security, their modern weapons. We have decided to open up arms exports. These are powerful systems, tested in a real war, when every international institution failed. We are also ready to grow our defence production together with strong partners so that their protection is modern and reliable. You do not need to start this race from scratch. We are ready to share what has already proven itself in real defence.

Thirdly, many in the world still feel relaxed. But look at how many representatives of countries are here, at this meeting of the General Assembly — countries that are at war, or just came out of war, or are trying to stop a war or openly getting ready for one. War has already reached too many people to pretend it has nothing to do with all members of the international community.

So, it depends on Member States — whether they help peace or continue trading with Russia and helping it to fund this war. It depends on Member States — whether prisoners of war will be freed, whether abducted children will come home and whether hostages will be free. It depends on Member States — what will define existence. Will it be war, as it does now, or will it be our joint strong actions, as it should be.

Yesterday, we had a good meeting with President Trump, and I also spoke with many other strong leaders. Together, we can change a lot. Of course, we are doing everything to make sure Europe truly helps. Of course, we count on the United States of America, and I appreciate the support we are receiving.

Much depends on the Group of Seven and Group of 20 countries. But, in the end, peace depends on all of us, on the United Nations. Do not stay silent while the Russia keeps dragging this war on. Please speak out and condemn it. Please join us in defending life and international law and order. People are waiting for action.

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of Ukraine for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Volodymyr Zelenskyy, President of Ukraine, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by His Serene Highness, Prince Albert II of Monaco

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): The Assembly will now hear an address by His Serene Highness Prince Albert II of Monaco.

His Serene Highness Prince Albert II of Monaco was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Serene Highness Prince Albert II of Monaco, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

Prince Albert (*spoke in French*): Eighty years ago, the creation of the United Nations marked a decisive turning point in the contemporary history of international relations, offering every State a forum for dialogue and exchange. The ambition of the founders was clear and bold: All nations, large or small, must be able to participate on an equal footing in developing collective solutions. Equality, respect and dialogue – this is the heart of the multilateral spirit. It is precisely these values that have allowed Monaco to find its place among the community of nations.

Over these eight decades, the United Nations has successfully navigated the major turning points in history: the reconstruction of Europe after the Second World War, the process of decolonization and the hope for a more peaceful international order after the cold war. The Organization has contributed to building a robust international law through the adoption of numerous treaties on subjects ranging from the law of the sea, to the fight against terrorism and from environmental protection to the promotion of human rights.

Monaco has ratified more than 270 of these treaties, which, far beyond their symbolic significance, regulate the daily lives of its population.

The United Nations has also played a central role in maintaining international peace and security. Across every continent, these operations have helped to prevent conflicts and support democratic transitions. International justice, in particular through the judgments and rulings issued by international criminal tribunals, has marked a major step forward in the fight against impunity for the most serious crimes, while the International Court of Justice remains a cornerstone of the peaceful settlement of disputes.

Furthermore, the United Nations has been a pioneer in raising environmental awareness and protecting our planet, mobilizing governments, scientists and civil society to develop coordinated strategies. Members know how important these issues are to me.

The United Nations has highlighted the role of sport as a vehicle for peace, inclusion and development. The Principality is pleased that sport is taking an increasingly important place in the work of the Organization.

Aware of the progress made over the past 80 years, we must be even more proactive in addressing the challenges that demand resolute and collective action. The positive record I have just outlined now contrasts sharply with a much darker reality. We live in a multipolar world in which national interests tend to take precedence over the pursuit of a common international ideal.

The proliferation of peacekeeping operations demonstrates that dialogue and preventive diplomacy have unfortunately not always yielded the desired results; international security is now seriously threatened. Regional tensions and conflicts spreading to the four corners of the world make it more essential than ever to reaffirm the founding principles of the United Nations: the sovereignty of States, the peaceful settlement of disputes and respect for international law and human rights.

In that regard, the Principality of Monaco strongly condemns the war of aggression against Ukraine and the suffering it inflicts on civilian populations. I was able to reiterate this message a few moments ago to President Zelenskyy. I hope that a just, lasting and negotiated peace agreement can be reached as soon as possible, guaranteeing security and meeting the aspirations of the Ukrainian people.

In the Middle East, the violence has resulted in unacceptable loss of life. The risk of regional conflagration demands immediate de-escalation, the protection of civilians, the unimpeded delivery of humanitarian assistance and a sincere relaunch of the peace process based on the two-State solution. Peace is not a utopia; it is an absolute necessity.

In addition to these security challenges, there are also environmental issues. The international community recently met in Nice for the third United Nations Ocean Conference, strongly reiterating the urgent need to act to protect the seas and oceans. In the run-up to this conference, the Principality organized the Blue Economy and Finance Forum, bringing together Heads of State, business leaders, investors, philanthropists, development banks and non-governmental organizations — 1,800 participants from nearly 100 countries answered the call and mobilized more financial resources to invest in a sustainable and regenerative blue economy. Yet, despite the commitments made, concrete actions are slow to follow.

The entry into force of the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction on 17 January 2026 must lead us to implement it without delay to ensure the conservation and sustainable use of biodiversity in the high seas. Combating climate change is a historic responsibility. The acceleration of extreme weather events demands immediate, credible and funded responses. Even as it faces a challenging period that requires unwavering support, scientific knowledge is abundant, accessible and more reliable than ever.

Moreover, the Paris Agreement, whose tenth anniversary we are celebrating this year, provides a structured and transparent framework that must build strong trust among all stakeholders. The announcement, in 2025, of new nationally determined contributions reflects this need to be even more ambitious.

I would like to reiterate that these commitments have not only a moral value, in particular with regard to young people and future generations, but also a legal value, as the International Court of Justice recently reminded us in its advisory opinion.

In that regard, and in line with the new collective finance target adopted at Baku in 2024, I have decided that my country will double its specific international climate action funding by 2028.

However, let us not forget that it would be futile to invest in the fight against climate change without addressing the global loss of biodiversity. The seventeenth meeting of the Conference of the Parties to the Convention on Biological Diversity, to be held in Yerevan in October 2026, is a crucial deadline for translating the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework into tangible results, in particular in terms of financing and the effective protection of ecosystems.

We cannot ignore the alarming erosion of human rights, the restriction of freedoms, the repression of civil society, the opposition and the excessive use of force. These abuses are undermining the very foundations of our Organization and fueling the crisis of confidence that citizens have in our institutions. Women's rights are a fundamental pillar of peace, development and justice. Thirty years after the Fourth World Conference on Women, held in Beijing, equality between women and men has still not been fully achieved universally, and we must reaffirm this as an absolute priority.

It is also urgent to foster collective mobilization against violence against women and girls and against all forms of persecution that they face, including in conflict zones. No society can prosper while such inequalities persist.

Likewise, no society can develop without nurturing its youth, because they are not only the future of the world, but are its present. It has been 30 years since the World Programme of Action for Youth was adopted, and it is up to us to strengthen the role of young people in economic decision-making processes and in civic life. Access to education, employment and digital training are not privileges, but rights.

Global public health cannot wait. Today, non-communicable diseases are the leading cause of premature death, and their prevention requires cross-sectoral mobilization. I commend the World Health Organization for its leading role in coordinating global action against those diseases. However, we must go further by strengthening synergies between stakeholders to improve the effectiveness of its actions, especially in a constrained budgetary context. The fourth high-level meeting dedicated to this issue must provide new impetus to intensify prevention and ensure universal access to quality healthcare.

The eightieth anniversary of our Organization offers an opportunity to revitalize multilateralism, reform its operations and address the liquidity crisis. Reforming our Organization must restore public trust and unite people within an effective structure centred on its founding values.

The United Nations remains the only universal institution capable of defending the sovereignty of States and embodying the ideal of cooperation among peoples. This is not limited to its Headquarters in New York. The specialized agencies — UNESCO; the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations; the World Health Organization; the United Nations Development Programme; the International Atomic Energy Agency and many others — play a vital role in providing concrete support for the social, educational and environmental policies of States. Let us allow them to fully carry out their responsibilities without duplicating mandates in New York, and let us refocus our Organization's work on the priorities enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations.

We must reconnect with the spirit of dialogue that inspired the creation of the Organization. The general debate must once again become that unique moment when leaders listen to one another, compare their visions and arrive at a better mutual understanding.

The Principality of Monaco hopes that, through reform, the United Nations will once again become the centre where nations' efforts to maintain peace and security are harmonized, in accordance with Article 1 of the Charter of the United Nations. No State

alone can resolve the crises of our time. It is by sharing ideas, resources and willingness that together we can build a future of peace and sustainable progress, because together we are better.

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Sovereign Prince of Monaco for the statement he has just made.

His Serene Highness Prince Albert II of Monaco was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Masoud Pezeshkian, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): The Assembly will now hear an address by His Excellency Masoud Pezeshkian, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Mr. Masoud Pezeshkian, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President (*spoke in French*): On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Masoud Pezeshkian, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Pezeshkian (*spoke in Farsi; English interpretation provided by the delegation*): The theme of this year, “Better together: 80 years and more for peace, development and human rights”, is in truth a summons to solidarity and to a shared vision of a brighter future. A religious conviction, as well as the call of the prophets, rests upon the equality of the rights of all human beings. What renders men more worthy is piety, namely truthfulness, wisdom, purity and benevolence.

The bedrock of all divine religions and of the human conscience is this golden maxim, that which you would not approve for yourself do not approve for others. Jesus Christ, peace be upon him, once said to do to others as you would have them do to you. The Prophet of Islam, peace be upon him, said that no one of you shall become a true believer until he desires for others what he desires for himself.

The sage Hillel the Elder expressed the essence of the Torah as such: that which is hateful unto thee, do not do to your fellow. In the traditions of the Orient, likewise, the central teaching is this very principle, and secular schools of ethics, grounded in reason and conscience, have arrived at the same conclusion.

Is this the state of our world? Let us behold the past two years, in which the world witnessed genocide in Gaza; the destruction of homes and repeated violations of sovereignty and territorial integrity in Lebanon; the devastation of Syria’s infrastructure; the assault against the people of Yemen; the forced starvation of emaciated children in the arms of their mothers; the assassination of Iran’s scientists; and the surreptitious raids infringing upon the sovereignty of nations, violating the territorial integrity of States and openly targeting leaders of people, all of this under the full support of the most heavily armed regime in the face of the earth, under the pretext of self-defence. Would Member States countenance such things for themselves? Who is the disturber of the stability of the region and the world? Who is the actual threat against international peace and security? Who is the violator of the golden maxim of mankind?

All members of the international community bore witness that, this past June, my country was subjected to a savage aggression in flagrant contravention of the most elementary principles of international law. The aerial assaults of the Zionist regime and the United States of America against Iran’s cities, homes and infrastructures, precisely at a time when we were treading the path of diplomatic negotiations, constituted a grave betrayal of diplomacy and a subversion of efforts towards the establishment of peace

and stability. This brazen act of aggression — in addition to martyring a number of commanders, citizens, children, women, scientists and intellectual elites of my country — inflicted a grievous blow upon international trust and the very prospect of peace in the region. If we fail to confront such perilous breaches of international norms, these aberrations shall spread and engulf the world.

The assault upon nuclear facilities under safeguards and international supervision, the open attempt to assassinate leaders and duly constituted officials of United Nations Member States, the systematic targeting of journalists and members of the press, and the killing of human beings who solely, by the reason of their knowledge and expertise, are converted into military targets. Again, would Member States countenance such acts for themselves? With this behaviour, they have killed at least more than 35,000 innocent civilians in Gaza. They have deprived them of food, drinking water, medication and proper healthcare.

Those who have perpetrated such crimes must know that the Islamic Republic of Iran, the most ancient continuous civilization on the face of the Earth, has always stood steadfast against the tempests of history. This nation, with a magnanimous spirit and an eternal will, has time and again demonstrated that it shall never bow before aggressors. And today, as well, in the face of the transgressors, it stands upright with reliance upon the power of faith and its national cohesion. In this 12-day defence, the patriotic and valiant people of my country laid bare before the aggressors the fallacy and self-delusion of their arrogant calculations. The enemies of Iran unwittingly fortified my country's sacred national unity. The people of Iran — despite the most severe, protracted and crushing economic sanctions, psychological and media warfare, and persistent efforts to sow discord at the very instant the first bullet was fired upon their soil — rose in unison in support of their valiant armed forces. And today they continue to honour the blood of their martyrs.

Here, on behalf of the Iranian people, I extend my heartfelt gratitude to all people, nations, governments, and international and regional organizations that stood in solidarity with Iran during this war.

Today, after nearly two years of genocide, mass starvation, the perpetuation of apartheid within the occupied territories and aggression against the Zionist regime's neighbours, the ludicrous and delusional scheme of a greater Israel is being brazenly proclaimed by the highest echelons of that regime. The scheme encompasses vast swaths of the region. The map itself lays bare the true intentions of the Zionist regime — intentions that have, of late, been openly endorsed by its criminal Prime Minister.

None in the world is secure from the aggressive machinations of this regime. It is manifest that the Zionist regime and its sponsors no longer even content themselves with normalization through political means. Rather, they impose their presence through naked force and have styled it "peace through strength". Yet, this is neither peace nor power. It is nothing but aggression rooted in coercion and bullying.

But we envision our powerful Iran alongside powerful neighbours within a strong region with a radiant future — a future in which we stand together against a grand project that imposes genocide, destruction and instability upon the region; a future in which collective security is assured through genuine mechanisms of defensive cooperation and joint response to threats; a future in which human dignity and cultural diversity are cherished as foundational values; a future in which collective development is realized through joint investment in infrastructure and modern science; a future in which energy security and the equitable use of vital resources emerges from the pillars of economic stability; a future in which the environment is safeguarded for posterity; a future in which national sovereignty and the territorial integrity of States are regarded

as non-negotiable principles; and a future not in pursuit of peace imposed by force, but founded upon strength derived through peace.

In such a strong region, slaughter and bloodshed shall find no place. It is for this very reason that my country has, for many years, been among the staunchest advocates of establishing a region free of weapons of mass destruction. Yet those who themselves possess the largest nuclear arsenals, and who, in flagrant breach of the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons, make their weapons even deadlier and more destructive, have for years subjected our people to pressures on the basis of spurious allegations.

Last week, three European States having failed — through a decade of bad faith and, thereafter, by supporting military aggression — to bring the proud people of Iran to their knees, at the behest of the United States of America, sought — by means of pressure, coercion, imposition and manifest abuse — to reinstate against Iran the Security Council resolutions that had already been terminated. In doing so, they set aside good faith and circumvented legal obligations. They sought to portray Iran's lawful remedial measures, taken in response to the withdrawal of the United States from the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), and to Europe's breach and utter incapacity, as a gross violation. They falsely presented themselves as parties of good standing to the agreement, and they disparaged the Iran's sincere efforts as insufficient. All of this was in pursuit of nothing less than the destruction of the JCPOA, which they themselves had once held as the foremost achievement of multilateral diplomacy. This unlawful measure, which has also met the opposition of certain members of the Security Council, possesses no international legitimacy and will not garner the endorsement of the international community.

I hereby declare, once more before the Assembly, that Iran has never sought and will never seek to build a nuclear bomb. We do not seek nuclear weapons. This is our belief based on the edict issued by the Supreme Leader and by religious authorities. Therefore, we never sought weapons of mass destruction, nor will we ever seek them.

Although it is Israel that disturbs the peace and stability of the region, it is Iran that is being punished for those actions. This brings to mind a poem that reads, roughly, that someone on one side of the world does something to disturb the peace, and someone else is punished for those actions.

The Islamic Republic of Iran welcomes peace and stability. We believe that the future of our region and of the world must be built upon cooperation, trust and shared development. In this framework, the Iran supports the peace process between the Republic of Azerbaijan and the Republic of Armenia and hopes that its outcome will be enduring and serve as a foundation for improved relations between these two neighbouring States.

Iran also hopes that the efforts to bring an end to the war in Ukraine will result in a just and lasting agreement between the Russia and Ukraine and bring solace to the human suffering caused by this crisis.

Iran welcomes the defensive pact between the two brotherly Muslim countries — the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia and the Islamic Republic of Pakistan — as a beginning for a comprehensive regional security system, with the cooperation of the Muslim States of West Asia in the political, security and defence domains.

Finally, Iran condemns the criminal aggression of the Israeli regime against Qatar, which resulted in the martyrdom of a number of Palestinian and Qatari nationals, and declares its support and solidarity with the government and people of Qatar.

True security is not achieved through force, but through confidence-building, mutual respect, regional convergence and multilateralism grounded in international laws.

Based on this foundation, I call upon all to practise listening to one another instead of raising voices; to re-examine the intellectual premises of polarization and political violence, which today not only ensnare the international community, but also create internal tension and turmoil within societies; to uphold as the common denominator of all beliefs and cultures the principles that whatever we do not approve for ourselves, we should not impose upon others, instead of distorting concepts and narratives with biased interpretations; to restore and rehabilitate the credibility of international laws, institutions and mechanisms; and to commit to the establishment of a regional system of security and cooperation in West Asia.

The President took the Chair.

We Iranians have extended our power in the world, not by producing and employing nuclear weapons, not by the slaughter of hundreds of thousands in the twentieth century, not by genocide and the imposition of starvation upon the children in Gaza in the twenty-first century, and not even through the historic empires of Iran, but rather through a culture of human fellowship and the message of empathy of universal sages, such as Rumi, Hafez and Saadi, who eight centuries ago declared,

> "Human beings are members of a whole, in creation of one essence and soul. If one member is afflicted with pain, other members uneasy will remain. If you have no sympathy for human pain, the name of human you cannot retain."

Those criminals who bully by murdering children are not worthy of the name human being, and they will never prove to be trustworthy partners. Relying upon its time-honoured tradition of altruism and human fellowship, Iran is a steadfast partner and a trustworthy companion for all peace-seeking countries of friendship and a partnership grounded not in fleeting expediency, but in dignity, trust and a shared future.

We, the upright people of the Islamic Republic of Iran, by standing firm against lawless marauders, have surmounted with honour the injustices, discriminations and double standards imposed upon us. Today, with an opportunity-oriented outlook, we have transformed this historic achievement of the Iranian people into a platform for a leap towards a hopeful future. Let us, together, turn threats into opportunities.

The President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank President of the Islamic Republic of Iran for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Masoud Pezeshkian, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. José Raúl Mulino Quintero, President of the Republic of Panama

The President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Panama.

Mr. José Raúl Mulino Quintero, President of the Republic of Panama, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. José Raúl Mulino Quintero, President of the Republic of Panama, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Mulino Quintero (*spoke in Spanish*): On behalf of the Panamanian people, with deep respect and renewed hope, I address the Assembly on the eightieth anniversary of the Organization, which continues to be a beacon of peace, cooperation and progress.

Since signing the Charter of San Francisco in 1945, Panama has committed itself to peace, security, sustainable development and human rights. For eight decades, our

country has championed multilateral diplomacy and public international law as a cornerstone of its foreign policy.

The UN80 Initiative, presented by Secretary-General António Guterres, offers an opportunity to reflect on the past and draw attention to the threats of the present in order to envision a more just future. We firmly believe that today, more than ever, we must strengthen the value of multilateralism to respond to global challenges and crises as a tool to mitigate asymmetries among nations.

In that regard, I want to emphasize that multilateral policy helped our country to be removed from the discriminatory lists on which the European Union and the Financial Action Task Force had placed us. It is incompatible to be a member of the Security Council and, at the same time, be on the same lists as countries that sponsor terrorism.

We believe that comprehensive reform is necessary to ensure that the Security Council is more effective, the General Assembly more representative and the specialized agencies more inclusive and, above all, to reduce bureaucracy. Panama, like other countries, is calling for greater representation of Latin America and the Caribbean in decision-making bodies. The time has come to update the architecture of multilateral governance.

Our region is the world's leading food exporter. It has a strategic canal linking the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans, and it holds more than 50 per cent of the world's biodiversity. We are major suppliers of minerals, we possess the largest water reserves, we live in peace and strive to preserve it. All of these factors make us a key player on the world stage, and we must have representation commensurate with our global role and importance.

In fulfilling its mission to contain and prevent the tragic outcome of a global war — a fundamental reason for its existence — the United Nations also faces the challenge of driving urgent action to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals.

Currently, the world is facing three devastating crises: climate change, pollution and biodiversity loss, all within a context of fragmented cooperation. The response to these crises must be swift and based on solidarity.

In response, Panama presented the Nature Pledge, our pact with nature. It is a new way of understanding environmental and climate policy within a framework that unites our obligations regarding climate, biodiversity and land into a single national commitment.

In practice, Panama commits to reducing its emissions by 2035. Even as a carbon-negative country, we believe that we can always take further steps towards sustainability for future generations. We will therefore restore 100,000 hectares of priority ecosystems, including mangroves and watersheds, because nature is our first line of defence against climate change.

Panama trusts in a renewed United Nations that strengthens digital security and international cooperation with ethical criteria and participation — one that supports just energy transitions and defends freedom of expression.

In that regard, we reiterate our unwavering respect for freedom and democracy in our region, which continues to suffer instability at the hands of those who do not respect the popular will expressed at the ballot box or who simply do not allow open and transparent elections.

We want to be part of a United Nations capable of preventing conflicts before they occur — one that can act promptly in humanitarian emergencies, better coordinates its agencies on the ground and more faithfully represents the diversity of people in the

world. Panama has offered to host offices of organizations of the United Nations system in support of reform efforts within the framework of the UN80 Initiative.

I also wish to express my solidarity with the Japanese people, on the twenty-third anniversary of the Democratic People's Republic of Korea's admission of the abduction of at least 17 Japanese citizens. The world needs to know the truth so that such events are not repeated. Japan deserves justice.

I cannot let this opportunity pass without highlighting that we have now reached a quarter of a century since the Panama Canal passed into Panamanian hands. As of 31 December 1999, the Republic of Panama assumed the construction and operation of the Canal, ensuring efficiency, safety, sustainability and neutrality, in accordance with the 1977 Panama Canal Treaty and the 1977 Treaty concerning the Permanent Neutrality and Operation of the Panama Canal, known jointly as the Torrijos-Carter Treaties.

Since then, we have managed the waterway in an exemplary manner, contributed to the country's economic development and operated the Canal for the benefit of international navigation. During this period, Panama expanded the interoceanic route using its own resources to meet the demand for larger vessels.

Now we are taking another step. We are supporting the Panama Canal Authority in the development of the Río Indio Reservoir, an ambitious project to guarantee water for the population and the Canal, ensuring that vessel traffic will not be threatened by the droughts that occur from time to time in our region.

Our waterway serves more than 180 maritime routes and more than 140 nations, and approximately 4 per cent of world trade passes through it. We are committed to ensuring efficiency in the service of international logistics.

Before the Assembly, Panama reaffirms, once again, its serious and sustained commitment to the regime established in the Treaty concerning the Permanent Neutrality and Operation of the Panama Canal, with an attached protocol to which numerous States have acceded. Neutrality is the most appropriate formula to protect the security of our Canal, an asset of global value. The neutral Panama Canal, open to the world and facilitating more integrated international trade, is and will remain Panamanian.

Panama holds a non-permanent seat on the Security Council for the 2025–2026 term. In August 2025, we held the rotating presidency of the Security Council, understanding it as a responsibility to maintain a strong voice in favour of peace, the sovereign equality of States, justice, international law and respect for agreements between countries.

We have also emphasized the importance of maritime security as a priority for our participation on the Council. Panama's national identity is closely linked to maritime transport. Throughout the centuries, we have consolidated our role as a key player in international navigation and trade. Piracy, arms and narcotics trafficking, and illegal fishing impact trade and the global maritime transport system.

As a transit nation and logistics hub of the continent, Panama suggests strengthening cooperation among specialized agencies, including a regional network to promote maritime security operating under the umbrella of ocean governance, in accordance with international law.

I want to reiterate here in the Assembly the work that this body must do to mitigate the effects of illegal migration, facilitated by organizations linked, directly or indirectly, to drug trafficking. For years, millions of people passed through the Darién Gap, on the Colombia-Panama border, and in just one year of management, we reduced the flow of migrants northwards to zero. That crisis was resolved, thus fulfilling the promise to

close the illegal crossings through the Darién Gap. The humanitarian and environmental consequences were extreme; the suffering of women and children who were victims of abuse, and the contamination of one of the most biodiverse areas in the world, still cause pain to those of us who have had direct contact with this situation.

Today, we have north-south migration on a much smaller scale, but it renews the commitment to the orderly transit of people so they can return to their homes. I must say that the migration crisis was resolved, but not the underlying causes that led to the massive migration.

The fact that our country has resolved this scourge does not mean we should cease demanding concrete solutions, as in the case of the border between Haiti and the Dominican Republic, which faces uncontrolled migration that also impacts the entire region. It is essential to find clear solutions, both for the Haitian crisis and for the effective control of migration flows.

Currently, we are also suffering from the growth of an illicit activity: drug trafficking. Today it constitutes a threat to people's lives and a very high risk of instability throughout the region, through the various cartels operating within it. To give a quick idea, this year alone Panama has seized nearly 150 metric tons of cocaine and other drugs — a historic and alarming figure. This compels us to redouble our efforts, seek greater cooperation and pool resources in a fight that must be a common cause among all nations.

In 2026, the Amphictyonic Congress of Panama, convened by the Liberator, Simón Bolívar, will celebrate its bicentennial. Their proposal is an international system based on the sovereign equality of States, justice, law and international cooperation to achieve common goals for all peoples. We hope that this commemoration will serve as a new starting point for international cooperation that respects and upholds the values of sovereignty, peace and peaceful coexistence, which should guide our work in this and other forums around the world.

Before this forum for world peace and international cooperation, I reiterate the Panamanian people's faith in the United Nations system. In times of crisis, when the winds of unilateralism, polarization and fragmentation blow, Panama will raise its voice in defence of multilateralism. Panama will continue to be an enthusiastic member of the United Nations, a defender of international law and a tireless promoter of world peace. Because, as this year's motto that brings us together says, united we are stronger. Only when we are united can we build a more just and humane future for all.

The President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of Republic of Panama for the statement he has just made.

Mr. José Raúl Mulino Quintero, President of the Republic of Panama, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Petr Pavel, President of the Czech Republic

The President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Czech Republic.

Mr. Petr Pavel, President of the Czech Republic, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Petr Pavel, President of the Czech Republic, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Pavel: I am humbled to speak here in front of the General Assembly again. Today, I wish to address two main issues: the achievements of the United Nations

and the necessity of its reform; and the prospect of multilateralism in the light of the Russian aggression.

Eighty years ago, the United Nations was founded with great hope to prevent war and destruction, and to never to repeat the horrors of the Second World War. My country stood proudly among the founding nations, signing the Charter of the United Nations, which would become our collective moral compass.

Since 1945, we have witnessed remarkable achievements. The United Nations helped to prevent another full-scale world conflict. It assisted the dissolution of colonialism and the rise of new sovereign countries in Asia, Africa, Europe and Latin America.

Together, we created a robust multilateral system of rules and global cooperation in international security, human rights and economic development. Together with the United Nations, we have fought famine, disease, illiteracy and poverty in some of the world's most vulnerable regions. Dozens of peacekeeping missions have helped to ease tensions in conflict zones.

Thanks to its long-standing efforts, the United Nations has helped to transform countless lives and laid the groundwork for a better world — one that is more humane and more cooperative. It provided a platform where even the smallest nations can speak out and be heard. The United Nations remains the only institution where the world can collectively confront global crises — not with weapons, but with dialogue, shared responsibility and pressure, where necessary.

The greatest achievement of the United Nations is not perfection, but persistence. With many ongoing devastating conflicts, Russia's invasion of Ukraine has significantly transformed the global security landscape. Since the most recent general debate, a year ago, our world has not become more secure.

On the contrary, in this game of smoke and mirrors, Russia continues targeting civilians, civilian infrastructure, foreign diplomatic missions and, most recently, even our neighbouring country, Poland, not to mention the acts of hybrid warfare on our own territory. These range from disinformation campaigns and attempts to undermine public trust, to cyberattacks and even acts of sabotage carried out by mercenaries recruited online. Despite being the largest country on the map, Russia still aims to seize Ukrainian territory and expand its sphere of influence, with the backing of China, Iran, North Korea and other countries that have helped it to circumvent sanctions and provide economic or political support.

Russia, a permanent member of the Security Council, is not only violating the principles of State sovereignty and territorial integrity enshrined in the United Nations Charter, but is also setting a dangerous example and precedent, sending the message that aggression can yield territorial and political gain and remain unpunished.

Our multilateral system was created on the premise that rules apply to all, without exception. The consequences of this war go far beyond the news headlines. This war threatens to dismantle our system of governance based on mutual respect, equal partnership and rules to which we all subscribed.

What is happening in Europe today could happen anywhere else tomorrow — under different circumstances, but under the exact same pretext. If Russia wins this unjust war, it will legitimize the triumph of brute force. Turning a blind eye to Ukraine today is a green light to any future aggressor, anywhere in the world. Disruptions of the status quo in the Taiwan Strait, or elsewhere in the Indo-Pacific, would further destabilize global security and trade. Geographical distance offers no protection. Security in one part of the world is directly linked to security everywhere.

Tolerating the principle of might makes right will lead to the end of multilateralism and the beginning of life under principles dictated by a powerful few. It would be a future with history deliberately rewritten, with lies promoted as facts and with truth slowly disappearing from our discourse and memory —the very opposite of what most of our nations fought for in the previous century.

The heroism of the Ukrainian people, their willingness to sacrifice for freedom, and global solidarity with Ukraine demonstrate that most of us still believe in universal values and in our responsibility to defend them.

To achieve sustainable peace, we, democratic allies from all over the world, must act in unity and intensify our economic pressure on Russian. This is the only way to bring the aggressor to the negotiating table. Such peace — based on existing international law, including territorial integrity and the right for self-determination — is in the interest of not only European countries, but of the whole international community. Any future peace agreement must send a clear message worldwide: aggressors must not be rewarded and borders cannot be changed by force.

The structure of the United Nations was based on the outcome of the Second World War. Today, one of the permanent members of the Security Council is waging a ruthless war while obstructing any constructive solutions put forward. It is in the light of these new geopolitical realities that we need a strong and effective United Nations system capable of responding to today's global challenges — from security threats and climate change, to the rapid evolution of new technologies. Otherwise, we risk sliding into a world that is more fragmented, more dangerous and far less predictable.

Czechia welcomes the UN80 Initiative and the commitments in the Pact for the Future. Yet, these ambitions stand in stark contrast with today's reality. In the light of the Russian aggression against Ukraine, the Security Council is currently failing its purpose and mission. Therefore, we advocate for a comprehensive reform of the Security Council for greater effectiveness, inclusiveness, transparency and accountability, with the aim of honouring the principles of United Nations Charter and to strengthen the voice of underrepresented regions.

Freedom and human rights are not granted entitlements. They are hard-won principles that must be cherished and protected. Security Council membership should not be seen as a matter of prestige or privilege, but, above all, a responsibility to defend global peace.

That is why Czechia is seeking a non-permanent seat on the Security Council for the term 2032–2033, with a clear commitment: to uphold the rules-based international order. We cannot afford to have the United Nations paralysed or blocked in its ability to respond to crises and challenges. Current urgent crises are already consuming too much of our attention and resources at the expense of other major, equally pressing issues.

As I mentioned at the beginning of my speech, the United Nations has significantly improved the quality of life of billions, including through access to education, healthcare and services. In this year's sustainable development report, Czechia ranked 10th out of 167 countries. I am fortunate to be a citizen of a country which, by global standards, offers a secure and comfortable life.

This does not mean that there are no challenges. Much work still lies ahead if we are to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030, both at home and globally. After all, most of the challenges we are facing are global. No single nation is powerful enough to succeed alone. That is why we need more dialogue. That is why we need greater cooperation and collective action. And ultimately, that is why multilateralism must not only survive, but thrive — not only for us, but most importantly for future generations.

The President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Czech Republic for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Petr Pavel, President of the Czech Republic, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Ms. Karin Keller-Sutter, President of the Swiss Confederation

The President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Swiss Confederation.

Ms. Karin Keller-Sutter, President of the Swiss Confederation, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations Her Excellency Ms. Karin Keller-Sutter, President of the Swiss Confederation, and to invite her to address the Assembly.

President Keller-Sutter (*spoke in French*): Eighty years ago, the world entered a new era, better times. On 27 January 1945, the concentration camp at Auschwitz was liberated. On 8 May 1945, the war in Europe ended, and on 25 June 1945, 50 States adopted the Charter of the United Nations in San Francisco. They were "determined to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war, which twice in our lifetime has brought untold sorrow to mankind".

Upon the ruins of the Second World War, a new international order was born out of a shared conviction and determination to bring peace and prosperity to the world. The horrors of this time also gave rise to the Geneva Conventions of 1949, which serve to protect the victims of armed conflict.

During those years, the foundations were laid for decades of progress in democracy, the rule of law and the market economy — foundations which, despite all the limitations and setbacks, also benefited international cooperation, free trade, peace and international law.

Without drawing any historical parallels, it is safe to say that the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations comes at a time when we are experiencing a new era of extremely violent political and economic upheaval — a time when, once again, there are too many wars, with civilian populations experiencing unbearable suffering; a time in which a just, lasting peace in the Middle East and Ukraine still seems out of reach, and in which autocratic tendencies are gaining ground, including in Europe. This is a time in which free trade is being put to the test and when, ultimately, international law, including the Charter of the United Nations, risks being no more than empty words.

These upheavals did not come out of nowhere; they are the result of developments that in some cases go back a long way and which, in retrospect, we failed to take seriously enough for far too long. We must be honest: These are developments that have no simple solutions, either at the international or the national levels. Nor is it enough to reiterate for the umpteenth time in speeches the merits of a particular form of government, the rule of law, international law, free trade and multilateralism. No, if we are serious about wanting to resolve these challenges, we must redouble our efforts.

For what are all the achievements of civilization worth if they do not tangibly contribute to freedom, security and prosperity, if they do not bring people real benefits in their everyday lives. There are two mistakes we must not make: First, we must not point our finger only at other States. Secondly, we must not leave international organizations to work alone and act as if they were completely detached from us.

We should begin there, where we can guarantee freedom and contribute to security and prosperity straight away. That is generally at home, in our own country. Do not get

me wrong: this is not about praising national self-interest or condemning multilateralism. On the contrary, Switzerland is convinced that multilateralism, international organizations and the United Nations are essential for the peaceful coexistence of peoples, for global economic prosperity, for resolving challenges such as migration, climate change and digital transition, and, as finance minister, for global financial stability.

Last year, we jointly adopted the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), underscoring our commitment to multilateralism. A central pillar of that Pact is the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. We must implement these road maps without delay.

Switzerland is also convinced that international Geneva can make a unique contribution to achieving these Goals. As the leading operational centre of the United Nations, Geneva has strong expertise in many areas that are crucial to our future, particularly those related to humanity and innovation. It is a unique ecosystem for reflection, discussion and joint action. But a strong international organization needs strong members.

When I say strong, I do not mean strength in terms of size or military might. I mean States that are able to offer their citizens an environment in which they are able to blossom and to express themselves freely in complete safety and security. I am referring to security not only in a military sense, but also legal, economic and social security. Security and freedom are essential prerequisites for economic growth and therefore prosperity. They require institutions that are legally sound, reliable and capable of taking action. They require political, social and financial stability. In that regard, each State must assume its own responsibilities. We cannot simply delegate our responsibilities to an international organization.

The international community benefits from the domestic strength, prosperity and stability of individual States. Only States that are strong domestically can show true solidarity and contribute to a successful international community. But we must also redouble our efforts as an international community.

Today, more than ever, the United Nations must take a critical look at itself: Is the Organization still able to fulfil its role as the 50 States intended when they adopted the Charter in San Francisco on 25 June 1945? Multilateralism is also undergoing unprecedented upheavals. These upheavals are marked by a resurgence of violations of the normative framework and the very principles and values that underpin multilateral action: principles and values such as dialogue, cooperation, consensus-building, respect for international law and sovereign equality of States, regardless of size, economic strength or political influence.

Switzerland calls on all States to make a firm commitment to uphold the principles and values enshrined in the Charter 80 years ago. Only then will it be possible to reflect on reforms and efficiency measures that strengthen the impact of our actions in the three pillars of the Organization.

With this in mind, we fully support the Secretary-General’s UN80 reform programme. Our decisions must be guided by the goal of strengthening the effectiveness, coherence, agility and impact of multilateral action. It is vital that we take a structured and thoughtful approach to defining, together, the United Nations of tomorrow.

I can assure Member States that Switzerland remains committed to the reform efforts, to a more efficient United Nations and to sustainable multilateralism, both as a reliable host State and as a committed Member State.

We are not in the same situation today as we were 80 years ago. We are, however, in the midst of a critical phase, and the next chapter of history has not yet been written.

This also means that we can play an active role in shaping it. In the words of another Auschwitz survivor, the Italian writer Primo Levi: “It happened, therefore it can happen again: this is the core of what we have to say.”

But it does not have to happen again. Indeed it must not happen again. That is why the United Nations was created 80 years ago. That is why we are here today. It is therefore up to us to ensure that this defining moment, which is so often talked about today, can mark the start of new era, just as it did 80 years ago. Let us guard against arrogance and complacency and set to work, at home, in our respective countries and together at the United Nations.

The President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Swiss Confederation for the statement she has just made.

Ms. Karin Keller-Sutter, President of the Swiss Confederation, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Edgars Rinkēvičs, President of Latvia

The President: The Assembly will now hear an address by His Excellency Mr. Edgars Rinkēvičs, President of Latvia.

Mr. Edgars Rinkēvičs, President of Latvia, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Edgars Rinkēvičs, President of Latvia, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Rinkēvičs: First, allow me to congratulate Your Excellency Annalena Baerbock on assuming the Presidency of the General Assembly. You, Madam President, will have Latvia’s full cooperation.

Latvia believes that we are stronger together — stronger in advancing peace, fostering development and upholding human rights.

Standing here, on this world stage, I would like to congratulate us on the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations. Eighty years working together to build a better, more just and peaceful world. This task has never been easy. But it is our duty to persist with determination and give our very best.

I want to express Latvia’s gratitude for the overwhelming support of our candidacy for the Security Council. Latvia will begin its term next year, our first term.

Latvia will take on this responsibility with a strong sense of duty: a duty to serve with integrity and transparency, and with a clear commitment to the principles of the United Nations. Latvia is honoured to serve on the Security Council for the good of people around the world. We will stand together for peace and resilience.

Latvia’s three priorities in the Security Council are: first, to protect our rules-based international order; secondly, to advocate for the women and peace and security agenda, as well as protecting the most vulnerable people among us; thirdly, to find solutions to emerging security threats, which include climate change, hybrid threats and the challenges related to the safety of artificial intelligence.

The world is in disarray. Before our eyes we see blatant attempts to weaken or even to destroy the rules-bases international order rooted in the Charter of the United Nations. In effect a new world order is emerging, and it is not a better one. There is an attempt to recreate the world where might makes right.

The permanent members of the Security Council undertook to maintain international peace and security, to prevent wars and to prevent devastation and loss of life. But it seems that one permanent member, Russia, does not want this.

Russia wants a world where brute force prevails over international law. It does not want peace. Russia wants to get what it wants, it is willing to inflict destruction and misery on others. Unfortunately, Russia has partners in crime, notably Iran and North Korea.

Ukraine is fighting back, bravely, with all it has. Ukraine is facing an existential threat — to its people, its land and its freedom. Ukraine is fighting for all of us – for the rules-based international order, for independence and sovereignty and for territorial integrity, so that international borders are not changed by force. These are actually the very principles at the heart of the United Nations.

Latvia stands with Ukraine and will advocate for its sovereignty and territorial integrity at the Security Council. We are and will be advocates for Ukrainian children abducted by Russia. They must be returned. We will be advocates for the Ukrainian civilians who have lost their homes and livelihoods. Latvia will use its position on the Security Council to help to achieve a just and lasting peace in Ukraine.

I want to express my appreciation to President Trump, President Zelenskyy and my European colleagues for their efforts to achieve peace, for trying to stop the unnecessary destruction and the misery we are witnessing in Ukraine.

It is our collective duty to uphold the principles of the Charter of the United Nations, especially when a permanent member of the Security Council openly violates them. We need no reminding that the United Nations was founded on the ruins of the Second World War, to save future generations from the scourge of war, to maintain international peace and security and to protect human life.

In war, it is the most innocent that pay the highest price. It is our duty to strengthen international cooperation to tackle the escalating crisis in Gaza. The humanitarian catastrophe in Gaza continues to spiral. Urgent action is needed to end civilian suffering.

Latvia condemns all terrorist attacks. Nothing can justify terrorism. We recognize Israel’s legitimate right to self-defence. But it must be exercised in line with international law and particularly international humanitarian law. The law is there to protect every one of us.

Latvia calls for an immediate ceasefire in Gaza. The terrorist organization Hamas must release all hostages. Hamas must be destroyed, as that organization is responsible for so much human suffering in the region. We need to ensure that access to humanitarian aid in Gaza is safe and unconditional.

The ongoing escalation confirms the need for a sustainable political solution; the need for a two-State solution in accordance with international parameters; the need to break the cycle of violence, to reach a just and lasting peace, a peace that addresses the security concerns and the legitimate aspirations of both the Israelis and Palestinians.

Latvia is keenly aware of the ongoing conflicts around the world. We must work together to resolve the dire humanitarian situation in the Sudan and the Democratic Republic of the Congo. We will not look on helplessly as crises unfold. As a member of the Security Council, we will call on the international community to take collective action and facilitate access to humanitarian aid, to try to end unnecessary human suffering.

We must do everything in our power to protect the most vulnerable people, especially women and children. Women and girls suffer disproportionately in times of

war. We, the global community, have a responsibility to protect the rights of women and girls, to empower them and to ensure their voices are heard in peace processes.

The forced deportation of Ukrainian children to Russia is beyond disturbing. We call on the United Nations to do much more. We will do all we can to help to bring these children home.

It is not only conventional warfare that threatens peace, security and stability. Emerging threats such as climate change, cyberattacks, hybrid attacks and the misuse of artificial intelligence are testing us daily. Our modern world is connected in ways that most of us cannot imagine. Today, many countries, including Latvia, are experiencing a growing wave of hybrid attacks. We have to deal with damage to undersea cables, GPS jamming, arson attacks and the Russian shadow fleet.

The Russia continues to carry out new provocations, most recently recklessly violating the airspace of Poland and Estonia. The intensity of the Russian Federation's drone attacks against Ukraine has created incidents in Latvia, Lithuania, Poland and Romania. This is the new reality. Russia bears full responsibility for these acts and their consequences. This kind of reckless behaviour is a direct threat to international peace and security, and we must act to stop it before such acts spiral out of control.

We must counter these threats by resilience and increased cooperation with our friends and allies. But hybrid warfare is evolving, as are emerging and disruptive technologies. The challenge is to maximize the benefits these technologies can bring, while remaining vigilant of the potential risk they pose.

We share the view of the United Nations that we need to develop artificial intelligence responsibly. But we should not halt the progress. Artificial intelligence can promote economic growth, drive scientific progress and innovation, even improve healthcare and make education more accessible.

Artificial intelligence is already part of our daily lives. We must acknowledge this reality and work to make it safer and more beneficial for the people. Governments should not take years to create regulations. We should act swiftly and do it right. As a responsible United Nations Member, a future Security Council member, Latvia is ready to work with our partners to address these issues.

Mr. Babo Soares (Timor-Leste), Vice-President, took the Chair.

The United Nations has stood the test of time for 80 years. It is the primary architect of international law and protector of the rules-based international order. The United Nations is not perfect, but it is the best we have. The only truly global Organization. As former Secretary-General Dag Hammarskjöld famously said, "The United Nations was not created in order to bring us to heaven, but in order to save us from hell".

But after 80 years, it is time to adjust to new realities. The United Nations must evolve to remain relevant, to be effective and fit for the challenges ahead. That is why we support the Secretary-General's UN80 Initiative. Let us work together for peace and resilience. Let us protect the rules-based international order and the Charter of the United Nations. Because we all are better together.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of Latvia for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Edgars Rinkēvičs, President of Latvia, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. William Samoei Ruto, President of the Republic of Kenya and Commander-in-Chief of the Defence Forces

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by His Excellency Mr. William Samoei Ruto, President of the Republic of Kenya and Commander-in-Chief of the Defence Forces.

Mr. William Samoei Ruto, President of Kenya, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. William Samoei Ruto, President of Kenya, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Ruto: I congratulate Ms. Annalena Baerbock on her election to preside over the eightieth session of the General Assembly. She can count on Kenya's full support throughout her tenure as she steers the Assembly into the future.

Eighty years ago, in the aftermath of unprecedented global destruction and devastating war, the international community came together in hope. They created this Organization, the United Nations, as a shield against the horrors of war, as a platform for dialogue and as a bridge to a better, fairer, more secure global community.

What is often forgotten, or not mentioned today, is that the United Nations grew out of the failure of the League of Nations, which existed between 1919 and 1945. The League of Nations did not collapse for lack of good intentions or noble objectives. Formed at the end of the First World War, and as part of the Treaty of Versailles, it was humanity's first attempt to build a permanent international organization to stop aggression, end war and bring nations together. Its ambitions were to achieve collective global security, disarmament, peaceful dispute resolution and cooperation on humanitarian and social issues.

Despite these ideals, the League of Nations failed. The United States of America never joined, other great powers came and went, and without enforcement authority its condemnations carried little weight. When Japan invaded Manchuria, when Italy marched into Ethiopia, and when Hitler openly defied its rules, the League stood by, helpless and powerless. By the late 1930s, its credibility had collapsed, and with the outbreak of the Second World War, it was rendered irrelevant.

This history is both a lesson and a warning. Institutions rarely fail because they lack vision or ideals; more often, they drift into irrelevance when they do not adapt, when they hesitate to act and when they lose legitimacy. To remain relevant, institutions must be reimagined, reformed, renewed and aligned with emerging realities.

Eight decades ago, the founders of the United Nations sought to correct the failures of the League, by creating a stronger, more inclusive organization, anchored in the principle of "We the people of the United Nations determined to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war".

Today, as we gather for the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations, the questions are unavoidable: Is the United Nations relevant to the demands of our time? Can it continue to serve humanity in the face of current realities? Or has it become a relic of a bygone era?

We meet against a grim global backdrop. Conflict rages in Eastern Europe, the Middle East, the Sahel, the Horn of Africa and beyond. Climate disasters grow fiercer by the day. Inequality deepens, pandemics loom and technological disruption outpaces governance. Instead of trust, mistrust is spreading. Instead of solidarity, fragmentation is taking root. In place of hope, anxiety fills our global community. We

are living — to borrow from the words of the founders of this institution — not in larger freedom, but in growing uncertainty.

At this moment of turbulence, when we most need a strong United Nations, the Organization faces its deepest crisis in credibility and capacity. Funding cuts have paralysed its operations. Bureaucracy has slowed its response. The Security Council remains frozen in the post-war structures of 1945, unable to act inclusively, with fairness and with speed.

I can, however, state with absolute conviction that the United Nations has been one of humanity's greatest achievements. For eight decades, it has held back the spectre of global war, calmed conflicts from Cambodia to Liberia, and stood guard in some of the world's most dangerous places through the courage of its peacemakers and peacekeepers. Few institutions in human history can claim such a legacy.

The United Nations has stood at the frontlines of humanitarian crises: from famine relief in the Horn of Africa, to emergency shelter for millions of Syrian and Ukrainian refugees. It was at the forefront of the eradication of smallpox, coordinated global responses to HIV/AIDS, Ebola and COVID-19, and continues to champion universal vaccination.

Its agencies have advanced women's rights, protected children, safeguarded refugees and set global norms on everything, from disarmament to climate action. The Sustainable Development Goals remain a shared blueprint for human progress. These are achievements no nation could have accomplished alone, however rich, great or powerful.

Yet, every institution, no matter how noble its origins or impactful its legacy, must adapt to changing times or slide into irrelevance. Today, the United Nations stands at a crossroads of renewal, on the one hand, or decay, on the other. Put differently, after 80 years, the rhymes of time are calling on us to reimagine the original promise that inspired the founding of the United Nations: the quest for global peace, development and human rights. But this call must now be answered in a global context that is profoundly different from the post-war era in which the United Nations was conceived.

We would be denying the cold, hard truth if we said that the United Nations is delivering as it should. On peace and security, its voice is too often drowned out by the rivalries of great Powers, while some nations simply ignore its resolutions and do as they please. Too often, the United Nations Blue Helmet, once a symbol of moral authority, no longer commands the same respect. From the conflicts in Gaza to Ukraine, to the crises in the Sudan, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Somalia and the Sahel, we see actors proceed undeterred by the calls of the United Nations.

Kenya speaks from the experience of a nation deeply invested in multilateralism. For decades, we have placed our troops and police in harm's way for peacekeeping missions across Africa and beyond — from Somalia to the Democratic Republic of Congo; from South Sudan to, most recently, Haiti, in our neighbourhood.

Over the past 15 months, we are proud to have led the Multinational Security Support (MSS) Mission in Haiti — not because it has been easy, but because solidarity is the essence of the United Nations. The Mission's mandate is coming to an end in a few days. As the leading nation, allow me to briefly share our experiences — the successes and the challenges — as both a cautionary tale and a living lesson about the strengths and weaknesses of the current global security governance architecture.

For far too long, the people of Haiti called out to the world. Too often, their pleas were met with silence, hesitation or half-measures. Haiti became a tragic

reminder of what happens when the international community looks away, prevaricates or offers half-hearted support.

When Kenya responded to the request of the Haitian authorities, it was in the belief that we were joining a genuinely multinational effort. We welcomed and fully embraced resolution 2699 (2023), by which the Security Council authorized the MSS, with Kenya as the lead nation. Drawing on our decades of peace support operations, we stepped forward, stepped up and deployed our officers to confront the rampant menace of gang violence in Port-au-Prince and its environs. The Mission has operated in a volatile environment under enormous constraints. It has been underfunded, underequipped and has operated below 40 per cent of its authorized personnel strength. Our police officers have valiantly shouldered responsibilities without the full logistical support that should accompany any mission sanctioned by the United Nations.

Despite these challenges, and against all odds, the MSS has delivered results many thought were impossible. The Presidential Palace, once under siege from gangs, is today restored as the seat of Government. The police headquarters and the police training centre, once overrun by gangs, are now secure, with the academy resuming the training of new police officers, more than 700 of whom graduated a few months ago. Schools that had been shuttered by violence have reopened, with children back in class, learning and progressing. Roads once manned or blocked by gangs now have free-flowing traffic. Cases of kidnapping and extortion have reduced sharply. The airport and seaport, once surrounded by gangs, are now abuzz with normal operations.

This begs the question: if so much could be achieved with limited resources and stretched personnel within just 15 months, what more could have been accomplished if the United Nations fraternity had truly acted together in solidarity with the people of Haiti?

From this podium, I wish to assure all partners and actors that, with the right personnel, adequate resources, appropriate equipment and necessary logistics, Haiti's security can be restored. Gangs can be neutralized, and the safety of streets, schools, hospitals and homes, secured. The continued harassment, abductions and criminal acts undermining the lives of Haitians are unacceptable, unjustifiable and must be stopped by this Organization — the United Nations.

As the Security Council deliberates on the next steps, we must not lose sight of the fact that the situation in Haiti demands sustained, coordinated and undivided international attention. A careful and orderly transition from the MSS is essential to consolidating the hard-won gains so far achieved. I urge the Security Council and all partners to remain steadfast in ensuring that Haiti moves forward on a path of peace, stability and renewal.

On human rights, our principle is clear and unwavering: the protection of civilians and respect for humanitarian law cannot be applied selectively. We cannot condemn suffering in one place and turn a blind eye to it in another. Kenya is gravely concerned by the humanitarian catastrophe in Gaza, and by the immense suffering of civilians caught in the devastation of disproportionate military operations.

At the same time, we call for the unconditional release of Israeli hostages. In line with the African Union and United Nations resolutions, we also call for a permanent ceasefire, for strict adherence to international humanitarian law and for the launch of a credible political process. Only through such a process can the vision of a two-State solution be realized — one in which Israel and Palestine live side by side, in peace, security and stability.

Kenya is also deeply troubled by the worsening humanitarian situation in the Sudan, where innocent citizens are caught in the crossfire of a needless war. We fully endorse the Quad — comprising Egypt, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and the United States of America — in affirming that there can be no military solution and that only political dialogue offers a viable path forward. We join the Quad in urging all parties, including the Sudanese Armed Forces, the Rapid Support Forces and external actors, to respect the Sudan's sovereignty, unity and territorial integrity and to firmly reject any attempt to divide the country, reaffirming our unwavering support for a unified country for the benefit of all of it people.

Those who look to the future with a clear vision know that climate change is not only the single greatest threat of our age, but also one of the greatest transformation opportunities of our time. The global stocktake has made it plain that the world is off-track. Current nationally determined contributions are steering us towards temperature rises far beyond any safe threshold. This is the difference between survival, on the one hand, and devastation for millions across the world, on the other.

Kenya and Africa are not passive victims of this crisis. We are taking bold steps, showing that climate action is not only possible, but can also be the foundation for inclusive growth. We are building a climate-resilient society by embedding adaptation into every sector, from agriculture and energy to infrastructure and livelihoods, to sustainable mining and artificial intelligence.

This ambition is visible on the ground. Today, 93 per cent of Kenya's electricity comes from renewable sources — geothermal, wind, solar and hydro. We are expanding investments in e-mobility, climate-smart agriculture, clean cooking solutions and green manufacturing. We are also pioneering nature-compatible solutions, such as sustainable waste management and circular economic interventions.

Africa, too, is uniting its voice. In 2023, in Nairobi, we hosted the inaugural Africa Climate Summit, where the continent adopted the African Leaders' Nairobi Declaration on Climate Change and Call to Action. Just two weeks ago, in Addis Ababa, Africa came together once again at the second Africa Climate Summit to reaffirm our commitments and strengthen our ambition for climate-positive growth. We declared Africa not just as a victim of the crisis, but as a source of solutions, with climate action driving economic growth, transformation and job creation for our communities.

Ambition cannot stand on willpower alone. Implementing our new nationally determined contributions will require $56 billion. That is why we call on the global community to unlock the $300 billion agreed at Baku and to accelerate negotiations towards the new $1.3 trillion goal under the Baku to Belém Roadmap to 1.3T. Without affordable finance and without reform of the international financial architecture, the promise of climate action in Africa will remain constrained.

In the aftermath of the Second World War, the Bretton Woods institutions were created to stabilize the global economy and rebuild war-torn Europe. At the time, their design reflected the power and interests of the victorious nations, who were also their primary shareholders and beneficiaries. The International Monetary Fund (IMF) was tasked with upholding the gold standard exchange-rate system, whereas the World Bank was established to finance Europe's reconstruction. Both have since evolved into development finance institutions, but their structures, decision-making and governance remain dominated by wealthy nations.

Today, the global context is vastly different. The gold standard collapsed five decades ago, and Europe has long since been rebuilt. Yet, the governance of these institutions has not kept pace with the needs of a multipolar world, especially the needs

of poor and developing nations. The mismatch between shareholders and stakeholders has become starkly visible. For instance, during the IMF's recent allocation of special drawing rights, 64 per cent went to wealthy nations, with little need for liquidity support. They did not need the money anyway but got 64 per cent. Meanwhile, the poorest countries received just 2.4 per cent — such a disconnect. This imbalance highlights how the very institutions meant to safeguard global financial stability often perpetuate inequality and instability.

I have argued — and I say it again — that the current global financial architecture punishes poor countries with high interest rates and enormous conditionalities, while rewarding rich nations with lower interest rates and softer lending rates. Its rules, priorities and allocation mechanisms consistently favour those already prosperous, while trapping vulnerable economies in cycles of debt, high borrowing costs and inadequate access to emergency support and concessional funding.

It is imperative to transform those institutions into genuinely independent, apolitical global bodies so that their operations are aligned with their global mandate. Such a shift would democratize decision-making, restore credibility and allow the IMF and the World Bank to serve all countries fairly, rather than reinforcing old hierarchies.

But Africa is not merely waiting for external prescriptions. We are taking bold and deliberate steps to strengthen our financial independence, safeguard our stability and accelerate our development. Kenya, for instance, fully endorses the establishment of the Alliance of African Multilateral Financial Institutions, launched with the African Union in February 2024. The Alliance brings together our homegrown banks: the African Export-Import Bank, the Africa Finance Corporation, the Trade and Development Bank, the Shelter Afrique Development Bank, the African Reinsurance Corporation, the African Development Bank, theAfrican Trade and Investment Development Insurance; and the PTA Reinsurance Company. Those institutions embody Africa's determination to mobilize resources, finance trade and build resilience on our own terms.

At the same time, the African Union is championing three transformative institutions: the African Central Bank, which will issue a single currency and free our trade from dependence on foreign money; the African Monetary Fund, positioned to stabilize our economies and give us true financial sovereignty; and the African Investment Bank, designed to mobilize resources for the infrastructure, industrialization and integration that Africa needs to rise. To complete this vision, the African Credit Rating Agency — one that understands our realities, values our uniqueness and tells our story with fairness and truth — has already been established.

As we mark the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations, Africa also marks 20 years since the Ezulwini Consensus and the Sirte Declaration, the two historic milestones that established the Common African Position on Security Council reform. For two decades, Africa has spoken in one voice, demanding justice, equity and representation in the highest organ of global governance. This demand, however, continues to be ignored, deferred or endlessly debated, to the detriment of both Africa and the legitimacy of the United Nations itself. One cannot claim to be the United Nations while disregarding the voice of 54 nations.

Africa is no longer willing to wait on the margins of global governance, while decisions about peace, security and development are made without our understanding, perspectives and voice. Africa's exclusion is not only unacceptable, unfair and grossly unjust, it also undermines the very credibility of the United Nations.

Africa dominates most of the Security Council's agenda, provides some of the largest contingents to United Nations peacekeeping forces, and bears the heaviest costs of instability. Yet we remain the only continent without a permanent seat at the main table, where decisions about our destiny are made. At the very least, Africa deserves

two permanent seats with full rights, including veto power, and two additional non-permanent seats on the Security Council.

The world must understand that reforming the Security Council is not a favour to Africa or anyone; it is a necessity for the survival of the United Nations. If the United Nations is to remain relevant in this century, it must reflect today's realities, not the post-war Power arrangements of 1945.

Despite the stated and evident weaknesses of the United Nations, it still remains humanity's best chance at global solidarity. No other institution has the universal legitimacy or convening power of the United Nations. From coordinating humanitarian relief in times of war and disaster, to mobilizing the global response to COVID-19, to driving consensus on climate change through the Paris Agreement, the United Nations has consistently shown that the world can achieve together what no nation can accomplish on its own, however mighty, great or powerful.

As Dag Hammarskjöld, the Organization's second Secretary-General, once observed, "The United Nations was not created to take humanity to heaven, but to save it from hell". That mission is as urgent today as it was eight decades ago.

At a time when conflicts are multiplying, when climate change threatens every economy, and when inequality is widening, the need for a functioning, credible and effective multilateral system has never been greater. It is through the United Nations that nations have pooled resources to vaccinate billions of children, to protect refugees through the work of the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees and to keep the peace in more than 70 missions worldwide.

Without the United Nations, these achievements, as modest as they may sometimes seem, would not have been possible. That is why we must resist the temptation to give up on the United Nations or to abandon it. We must make it fit for purpose, reform its structures, strengthen its mandate and ensure that its decisions reflect today's realities rather than the geopolitical map of a bygone era.

As one of the hosts of a United Nations headquarters, and the only one in the global South, Kenya stands ready to do its part to enable the Organization to go through this phase of renewal successfully, as envisaged by the Secretary-General under UN80 Initiative reforms.

In conclusion, the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations must be more than a commemoration; it must be a turning point for the Organization. Let us seize this moment to reimagine and rebuild the United Nations into a body that commands legitimacy, responds with speed and delivers justice for all.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Kenya and Commander-in-Chief of the Defence Forces for the statement he has just made.

Mr. William Samoei Ruto, President of the Republic of Kenya and Commander-in-Chief of the Defence Forces, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Santiago Peña Palacios, President of the Republic of Paraguay

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Paraguay.

Mr. Santiago Peña Palacios, President of the Republic of Paraguay, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Santiago Peña Palacios, President of the Republic of Paraguay, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Peña Palacios (*spoke in Spanish*): This is my third address to the General Assembly. It is, without a doubt, an enormous privilege and honour to represent, in this great forum, Paraguay, a country that may seem geographically small, but is a giant in its spirit and potential.

Therefore, as I flew into New York from afar, I thought of beginning this speech by expressing the joy I feel at having the opportunity to tell you about the great things that await Paraguay. However, the events of recent days and months make this simply impossible.

Instead, I must sadly begin by recalling the anecdote of the great German historian Theodor Mommsen, who, upon receiving the Nobel Prize in 1903, asked his audience not to applaud after his acceptance speech. “The times”, he said somberly, “are too grave for that”.

The following years would fully confirm his intuition. I believe that exactly the same can be said now. Indeed, in recent days we have seen that evil, radical ideology and intolerance are, unfortunately, real and deeply rooted in certain sectors of our societies.

I am still shocked, and also saddened and grieved, by the shocking images of two cowardly and incomprehensible political attacks. First, intolerance and hatred took the life of a great human being, Miguel Uribe, the Colombian presidential pre-candidate, who was assassinated in public during a campaign event. The spectre of violence, which we thought was a thing of the past for our Colombian brothers and sisters, has returned. Second, we saw a young dreamer, Charlie Kirk, tragically taken from his wife and two children for a single sin: defending his convictions and values with great eloquence and courage.

Instead of resorting to violence to impose their ideas, both used the most civic and peaceful method possible: free, open and frank debate, without shying away from controversial positions, but always within a framework of respect. The ominous, macabre response must awaken us from our complacent state.

Our values, our very way of life, are in danger. The idea of democracy, that venerable and brilliant creation of Greek genius that allows us a peaceful way of life despite our differences, is today at risk. Therefore, in times when darkness seeks to extinguish the light, we must take a stand. This is no time for timidity: either we are on the right side of peace and reason, or we are on the side of violence and intolerance.

Our children and grandchildren will not forget the stance we have taken in the face of the enormous challenge we face. That is why I want to be very clear with you: political violence is immoral, intolerable and profoundly damaging. We must reject it unequivocally. Therefore, let us say loud and clear: no to hatred, no to violence and no to authoritarianism.

We must not underestimate the gravity of what is happening. These are not isolated cases; they are patterns. The situation has been worsening before the impassive gaze of governments and political movements. Polarization and extremism, previously subtly revealed in texts and speeches, are now materializing in real acts of violence. There is a crisis of faith in institutions: citizens simply no longer trust them.

Our democracy, a democracy that for decades has guaranteed the most fundamental human rights, embodied in the magnificent instrument known as the Universal Declaration of Human Rights — an enduring achievement of the United

Nations system — is besieged from all quarters and spectres, from both the left and the right. This could be a point of no return. This crisis situation is the perfect breeding ground for authoritarianism. Where democratic values erode, and authoritarianism — or its perverse twin, populism — takes its place.

Paraguay views with enormous concern the restrictions on the exercise of fundamental rights, such as access to free information and freedom of expression in some sister countries, which are already tangible demonstrations that the crisis is real and profound.

Thus, unfortunately, the situation in Venezuela has become truly alarming. In addition to systematic violations of human rights and fundamental freedoms, we see actions contrary to international law, as well as the persecution of political leaders. The electoral process of July 2024 trampled on the will of the Venezuelan people. Seven million Venezuelans have left their homeland — the largest migration crisis in the history of the western hemisphere.

In Nicaragua, the persecution of political opponents persists and is expanding aggressively. The situation regarding human rights and fundamental guarantees is extremely serious. Entire religious orders have been expelled. Hundreds of Nicaraguans have been stripped of their nationality. Their only crime was dissent. Even the Catholic Church is being persecuted — something once unthinkable in Latin America.

Paraguay knows better than anyone the calamity of authoritarianism and dictatorship, for we lived through the longest military regime on the continent in the twentieth century, whose scars have not yet fully healed. That is why we cannot, and must not, remain silent while our Latin American brothers and sisters suffer the same oppression that has seared our past.

The crisis of democracy, my friends, is not resolved with an iron fist, censorship, authoritarianism or, much less, violence. We must resist these alluring imposters.

As the Italian philosopher Norberto Bobbio said, crises of democracy are resolved only with more democracy, not with authoritarian puppets, or with hatred or intolerance. We must respond with more democracy, more republic, more tolerance, more dialogue, more rights and more freedom.

The raison d’être, the very essence of the United Nations is and will always be the maintenance of peace. However, as we gather here, more than 120 armed conflicts demonstrate how grave the failure of our institutions can be. Paraguay extends its solidarity with all victims of armed conflict and advocates, once again, for the peaceful resolution of disputes.

I want to highlight today, in particular, the painful situation in Haiti. The time for decisive and coordinated action by the United Nations, and especially by the Security Council, is now; Paraguay knows this and is ready to help the Haitian people, who can no longer wait.

On the other hand, I want to emphasize a situation that goes beyond armed conflicts but is just as serious. We are facing a silent but devastating crisis: the collapse of global supply chains. The pandemic showed us how fragile they were. The war in Ukraine strained them even further. And now, geopolitical fragmentation threatens to break them completely.

The world urgently needs more reliable, more diversified and more resilient supply chains. We cannot continue to rely on systems that prioritize efficiency over safety, cost over reliability.

Let me be clear: not all trade partnerships are created equal. We must be wary of deceptive economic models that come hand in hand with political authoritarianism, mass

surveillance and the erosion of fundamental freedoms. When we accept investments that compromise our sovereignty, when we allow our critical infrastructure to depend on authoritarian regimes, we are mortgaging not only our economy, but also our democracy.

That is why we advocate for deeper integration among our countries, based not only on trade, but also on shared values: the rule of law, individual freedoms, a free market economy, the defence of the traditional family and the right to life from conception. That is why Paraguay's foreign policy is not based on mere self-interest, but on these shared values and principles. For those reasons, Paraguay cannot and must not evade the realities that challenge world peace. Diplomatic prudence cannot become silent complicity. It is precisely at these moments that the principles that define us as a democratic nation must translate into clear and unequivocal positions with our friends and allies.

Paraguay hereby reaffirms its unambiguous position: Israel has the legitimate right to defend itself. The terrorist attacks of 7 October 2023 against Israeli civilians were grotesque acts of barbarism that no cause can justify. We reject any attempt to equate, in a biased manner, the responsibility between the democratically elected authorities of Israel and the leaders of the Hamas terrorist group.

Antisemitism, as daily events demonstrate, is not an accident of the twentieth century: it is alive and well. It is part of that cycle of irrational violence and hatred that I mentioned at the beginning of my remarks. I must confess here that I have never understood how so many people have adopted this horrific worldview, given that the Jewish people have given so much materially, culturally and spiritually to the world. Yet, sadly, this perversion persists among us. The only response is to be vigilant. Say no to hatred. Shoah Never Again.

This is why Paraguay was one of the first countries in the world to designate both Hizbullah and Hamas as international terrorist organizations and has always strongly condemned their evil actions. I resolutely condemn these criminal organizations once again today before all of you.

My country will continue to oppose those who deny the sacred value of human life, a fundamental idea in the Paraguayan worldview.

We also make an urgent call for the implementation of a solution that alleviates the humanitarian situation in the Palestinian territory, puts an end to the violence and guarantees the immediate release of the hostages, promoting a constructive dialogue that leads to peaceful coexistence between both peoples and is a source of lasting peace in the Middle East region.

Paraguay's principled diplomacy, based on conviction and not mere expediency, also explains our moral firmness regarding another democracy facing existential threats. Consistency in defending democratic values does not allow for selective geographies or calculations of convenience. Principles, when genuine, are upheld by their intrinsic value, not by their political expediency.

Paraguay has proudly maintained 67 years of diplomatic relations with the Republic of China (Taiwan). This friendship, forged on shared democratic values, has demonstrated that cooperation between nations can be based on more than mere self-interest. This decision certainly comes at a significant economic cost, but believe me the value of doing what is right is priceless.

The growing tensions in the Taiwan Strait deeply concern us. The increasingly aggressive military exercises, the constant air incursions and the bellicose rhetoric all point to a dangerous escalation that could destabilize not only Asia, but the entire global order. It must be said without hesitation or cowardice: Taiwan deserves a place in this forum. It is a matter of strict justice. Its exclusion from the United Nations system is an

affront that undermines the legitimacy of our institutions. Twenty-three million decent, hardworking and dignified people cannot remain invisible to multilateralism.

As in other cases, the question of Taiwan and its international status must also, without exception, be part of the debates of the General Assembly. It is time to uproot this tree of injustice that has been growing for decades and give Republic of China (Taiwan) a place in the United Nations.

Those principled positions, based on convictions and not expediency, give Paraguay something relatively scarce these days: genuine moral authority to discuss the problems that afflict us. In this context of global crisis, Paraguay reaffirms itself as a middle Power, with a central role in building consensus and strengthening the multilateral system.

The facts bear out our words: Paraguay proceeds with a characteristically constructive spirit in the debates of the multilateral system. In line with this active role, my country is currently a member of the Economic and Social Council, and we have national experts on the International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea; the Human Rights Committee; the Committee on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights; the International Narcotics Control Board; and the Advisory Committee on Administrative and Budgetary Questions, among others.

In the 2026–2027 period, we aspire to the presidency of the Bureau of the Sixth Committee of the General Assembly and will assume the responsibility of being members of the Peacebuilding Commission. Paraguay stands ready to take its place in the concert of nations, not as a mere peripheral voice, but as a true leading actor in the search for solutions to global problems.

Therefore, Paraguay accepts and commits to the objectives proposed in the Secretary-General's UN80 Initiative, which include seeking greater efficiency in the use of existing resources, simplifying processes and reviewing the implementation of mandates. To that end, Paraguay demands the implementation of geographical balance in the appointment of the next Secretary-General, to strengthen the legitimacy and representativeness of this Organization. In this process, we are convinced that our region must be considered, as it has candidates who meet the highest standards of experience, integrity, vision and, above all, leadership to build bridges that will help us to overcome challenges with global impact and systemic risk.

Therefore, Paraguay demands a profound reform of the Security Council to prevent it from becoming dispensable within a multilateral system that needs to provide solutions to the numerous current conflicts, both those between States and those caused by non-State actors. We call for more flexible positions so that the Security Council can once again be truly representative of its membership and regain its effectiveness in fulfilling its mission.

We demand the elimination of the veto, which will give greater legitimacy to the body and allow the United Nations, as a universal organization, to once again play a leading role in determining solutions to the major challenges facing our world.

I know that the picture I have presented so far is not the best, indeed it is even bleak, but I have preferred to speak the truth, without mincing words, so as not to underestimate the gravity of our current situation. And yet, being the optimist at heart that I am, I cannot help but say this: I look to the future with hope. As the great writer William Faulkner said, "I believe that man will not merely endure; he will prevail." With all of our flaws, when we work together, when we prioritize solidarity over separatism, dialogue over violence and tolerance over hatred, humanity is capable of great things. Building the future is not possible simply by making a wish. Building the

future requires intention, persistence, perseverance and discipline. I always say, and I repeat it today: there are no shortcuts to development, only hard work.

But words are no longer enough. Our people are tired of empty promises, with grandiloquent declarations that do not translate into food on the table, safety in the streets or education for their children. As in any relationship where trust has been broken, the key to rebuilding it is to show results. Democracy must demonstrate that it can deliver, that it can generate prosperity, that it can ensure justice and offer hope, and that it can be a democracy with a human face, with social substance, such as the one championed by the great thinkers of my political group, such as Ignacio A. Pane, Juan León Mallorquín and Fulgencio R. Moreno.

All of this has been demonstrated by my party in its role as the governing party of Paraguay in recent decades: that it is possible to achieve economic growth with justice, democracy and human rights. I say this not with arrogance, but with the humility that characterizes us Paraguayans, a humility born from a history of greatness, but also of suffering. We Paraguayans know the eternal cycle of rebirth: emergence, crisis and tragedy. We have had to reinvent ourselves and rise from the ashes. In that noble process, we have built the Paraguay that today, finally, is being recognized for what it is: a giant that rises again.

While the world falters, we are building something different — a model that works, and a model that inspires confidence because it delivers results.

The numbers speak for themselves. We had economic growth of 5.2 per cent in the first half of 2025, while the region averaged only 2 per cent. Our inflation is under control, under 5 per cent, below the regional average. We are making steady progress towards post-pandemic fiscal convergence. Our fiscal deficit returns to 1.5 per cent in the national budget for 2026. Our unemployment rate has fallen to historic lows.

However, growth without social justice is meaningless. That is why we have implemented ambitious programmes that are transforming the lives of the most vulnerable. Our Zero Hunger in Schools programme feeds more than 1 million children daily in 7,000 schools. The “Che Róga Porã” programme is helping thousands of working families become homeowners. For the first time, the Government is offering mortgages with monthly payments equivalent to rent, transforming a monthly expense into family assets.

I want to highlight that 120,000 people have been lifted out of poverty in just one year. Extreme poverty has fallen to 4.1 per cent, the lowest level in our history.

None of this would be possible without strong institutions. That is why we have undertaken bold reforms: We promoted the Civil Service Law to professionalize the public sector, ending decades of patronage. With the Integrity and Transparency Law, we created real mechanisms for control and accountability, strengthening the Comptroller General’s Office. We approved the Unified National Registry Law, which proposes a structural transformation and, after more than 100 years, brings order to real estate ownership in Paraguay. The result was that, in July 2024, Paraguay achieved investment grade status for the first time in its history.

The Paraguayan model is not perfect, of course. We have enormous challenges, and much remains to be done. But we are changing the reality. We are demonstrating that today Paraguay is not just a country. As the President of the International Automobile Federation, Mohammed Ben Sulayem, said during the World Rally Championship in Paraguay: Paraguay is “the country”.

I began this speech with some rather sombre warnings about the state of global democracy and our societies. These are serious times, and there is much to worry about. But I do not want to end on a pessimistic note – a different, better, brighter future is

possible. It is up to us, all of us, to identify the problems with courage and address them with perseverance and conviction. The future is not predetermined. Paraguay is living proof that, even in the face of the chaos and desolation of war, it is possible to rebuild. It is possible to reconcile prosperity with justice, growth with sustainability and openness with sovereignty.

Paraguay is ready to be part of the solution. The sleeping giant of South America has awakened and is rising with strength. We are ready to be a central protagonist in the fight for humanity's great values, to be a leading actor in the concert of nations. That is because we believe in a future where democracy not only survives but flourishes; we believe in a future where development reaches everyone, not just a few; we believe in a future where cooperation is based on shared values, not expediency; we believe in a future where trust is earned through results, not rhetoric; and we truly believe that humanity will not only endure; it will prevail.

That different future is possible. We Paraguayans are building it every day. I invite the international community to build it with us, all together, to leave a better world for our children and grandchildren – a world with more democracy, more freedom, more tolerance and more justice. A world where hope defeats pessimism, light prevails over darkness and good triumphs forever and ever over evil.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Paraguay for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Santiago Peña Palacios, President of Paraguay, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Alar Karis, President of the Republic of Estonia

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by His Excellency Mr. Alar Karis, President of the Republic of Estonia.

Mr. Alar Karis, President of Estonia, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Alar Karis, President of Estonia, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Karis: The United Nations represents an idea of a better world, an idea that is not an abstract construction or an empty declaration, but a carefully crafted agreement: a grand agreement that is the basis for the current multilateral world order; an agreement designed to protect international peace and foster prosperity; an agreement to ensure a free and dignified life for everybody; an agreement that is based on the understanding that destruction and horrors of war must not be repeated.

Unfortunately, the international law-based multilateral system, with the United Nations and its Charter at its core, which was supposed to keep us all safe, is increasingly under strain. Its fundamental principles are violated in numerous conflicts across the world. Brutality prevails. We simply cannot let this go on.

We all should be asking the kind of future we want. Will it be a world dominated by barbaric use of force and violence, where might is always right? Or do we want a peaceful and prosperous world where law and order, justice and universally agreed rules and principles prevail? This question is relevant for everyone in this Hall, despite of the distance of our own homes from the front lines in Ukraine, Gaza, the Sudan or the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

A multilateral world order based on international law and the principles of the Charter of the United Nations must be maintained and strengthened. What our peoples

are expecting from us as world leaders today is to bring back the San Francisco spirit, to preserve peace and to reinforce the principles of the Charter.

Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine constitutes one of the gravest breaches of international law and the Charter of the United Nations since its adoption 80 years ago. Despite repeated calls by the General Assembly to stop the aggression and set the course towards peace, Russia continues its savage assault on the Ukrainian State and nation. Russia's war and its war crimes are undermining the reputation and credibility of both the Security Council and the entire United Nations. This blatant assault on the principles of the Charter is undermining multilateralism, global peace and security.

Regrettably, as we speak, the Russian Federation is targeting Ukrainian kindergartens, schools, hospitals, nurseries with missiles, drones, gliding bombs, mines, shells and bullets. The same permanent member has been systematically abducting and deporting Ukrainian children, erasing their identity and forcing them into indoctrination.

Human suffering in Ukraine has reached unprecedented levels. The human rights monitoring mission in Ukraine alone has documented the death of at least 14,000 civilians, including almost 1,000 children, and approximately 35,000 injured civilians, including more than 2,000 children. The death toll increases with every year, month, week and day.

In total disregard of President Zelenskyy's agreement to a ceasefire in March, and of the recent peace efforts by the United States of the America, Russia has significantly intensified its campaign of terror with a barrage of drone and missile strikes on civilian targets.

It is evident that the Russian Federation has no intention of agreeing to a ceasefire, let alone a lasting peace. Russia's objectives have not changed. They remain the subjugation of all of Ukraine and the reshaping of Europe's security order to satisfy the Russia's own neocolonial and imperial ambitions.

The increasing violations of neighbouring countries' airspace by Russian drones and missiles are yet another escalation and a stark reminder that Russia's aggression threatens, not only Ukraine, but also the security of the entire region.

I hereby must regrettably tell Members that just days ago, Russian fighter planes violated Estonian airspace, a hostile act that is part of a pattern of similar recent incidents happening on the European Union's eastern border. Therefore, the only viable way forward towards a ceasefire and just and lasting peace is to increase collective international pressure on Russia, to force it to accept peace in Ukraine and to act in a way that is expected from a permanent member of the Security Council.

Let me assure the Assembly that my own country, Estonia, will continue to do everything possible to reinforce Ukraine's ability to defend itself in full conformity with Article 51 of the Charter of the United Nations. Doing so, we are defending the sovereign equality of all Member States, large and small — one of the core principles on which the United Nations was founded.

We are also advocating for making Russia accountable for all of its crimes in Ukraine, including for the crime of aggression, as we know too well that impunity only leads to new crimes, new suffering and even greater injustice.

The international law-based multilateral system has also failed to protect Palestinians and Israelis. Having visited both Israel and Palestine this year, I witnessed first-hand the devastating impact of this long-lasting conflict. Hamas's brutal terrorist attacks on 7 October have been condemned by the whole world. Hamas cannot have any role in the future governance of Gaza and Palestine. It must be guaranteed that the horrors of terrorism will never be repeated.

However, ordinary people and children in Gaza must not be the ones to pay the price. I am devastated that so many innocent lives, including children's lives, have been lost due to military action, starvation and the spread of disease. The promise of international humanitarian law was to ensure that people do not suffer during armed conflict. Yet, what has unfolded in Gaza has crossed all red lines.

Estonia has supported all efforts for a ceasefire that would end the killing and destruction of lives, and bring all the hostages home. In order to alleviate the unbearable humanitarian situation, Israel must fully respect international humanitarian law and implement its commitments regarding access and the delivery of humanitarian aid and security of aid workers.

In order to truly end the cycle of violence, we need a comprehensive political process with the end goal of two States, Israel and Palestine, living side by side in peace and security. I commend the efforts of France and Saudi Arabia to step up international action to implement the two-State solution.

The United Nations must be capable of fulfilling its core functions. In order to face the multitude of current global challenges, all the pillars of the United Nations — peace and security, human rights and sustainable development — must be strengthened.

Estonia, therefore, supports an ambitious system-wide reform of the United Nations. This is not only an issue of monetary efficiency and financial discipline, but a structural problem and a matter of credibility for the United Nations. For that reason, we are fully behind the Secretary-General's endeavours to vigorously promote the UN80 reform process.

Within that transformation, the reform of the Security Council is of central importance. Estonia supports the expansion of the Council membership to include countries that have, inter alia, demonstrated their unwavering commitment to international law and the principles of the Charter of the United Nations and have consistently acted in accordance with these principles. Furthermore, if we want to have a functional and respected Council, we also need to restrict the use — or rather abuse — of the veto, and increase the transparency of the Council's work and its accountability.

Last but not least, we also need to ensure transparency when it comes to the selection of the next Secretary-General. After 80 years of men-only leadership, we are very supportive of the idea that it is high time for a woman to be chosen as the Secretary-General, based on a fair process seeking the most qualified candidate. We need to put forward ambitious selection criteria and clear timelines, and ensure that the General Assembly plays a greater role in this process. Given the current credibility crisis of the United Nations, we cannot afford to fall short in the selection process.

Sustainable development with clearly defined goals remains a central focus of the United Nations. We have to redouble our united efforts to address global challenges, such as the effects of ongoing climate change, which are getting worse in all parts of the world.

The upcoming thirtieth session of the Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (COP30) in Brazil should be a turning point. Countries should submit strong climate plans, which should cover all parts of the economy and follow the 1.5°C goal of the Paris Agreement. Substantial progress during this decade is crucial.

We must work together to triple renewable energy production by 2030, because this is the most effective way to reduce emissions. Estonia shows that this is possible. We used to rely on oil shale, a local fossil fuel, for our energy production. Yet today, nearly 40 per cent of our electricity comes from renewable sources. This change happened because of political will and private investments.

Let us now raise our ambitions together, like we did when we agreed on a world clean-up day to be acted upon on 20 September, at Estonia's initiative and example worldwide — not to celebrate it, but to do it.

In the myriad challenges we face, accessible education is a prerequisite for understanding current problems, learning from the mistakes of the past and crafting a better world. Estonia's educational system ranks high in many international rankings. We see how this has had an impact to many other fields where Estonia has been doing well, including digital governance, media freedom and innovation.

Our goal is to share with our partners — including through the UNICEF Executive Board — our diverse experience in innovation in education, developing education policies, reforming education and improving the availability of high-quality education.

Every situation, every culture and every context is unique and requires specifically developed solutions. However, allow me to draw the Assembly's attention to one of our experiences. In 1991, at the start of the Internet revolution, we decided to radically integrate computers and the Internet into our education system. The programme Tiger Leap, the aim of which was to open a computer class in every Estonian school within a year, was a cornerstone of Estonia becoming one of the most digital societies in the world today.

The world today looks different than it did 34 years ago. But new technology is there again and waiting to be put into best use. Therefore, Estonia is making a new leap — the artificial intelligence (AI) leap. We are again providing the best technological tools available to our students and teachers so that we can keep the comparative edge in education for years to come. Equipping citizens with the skills to use AI wisely and responsibly is essential. AI must serve dignity, development and human rights — not the other way around.

In Estonia, we believe in innovation, and we are most ready to develop new tailor-made solutions with our good partners all around the globe. In collaboration with the International Telecommunication Union and Germany, Estonia co-founded the GovStack initiative. This innovative platform provides governments with a digital public infrastructure toolbox aimed at modernizing digital services by creating a modular, open-source and scalable framework for governments worldwide.

Whichever global problem we approach, we have to build on human rights and basic freedoms. Yet today, human rights and fundamental freedoms are increasingly under pressure worldwide. This is a deeply worrying trend that demands our collective response. This is also the idea that guides us on the way of becoming a member of the Human Rights Council for the 2026–2028 period. I ask for everyone's support at the elections next month.

Our priorities during our membership would be the promotion and protection of children's rights, safeguarding digital rights and reducing the digital divide, and advancing media freedom. All three are critical for advancing democracy and protecting the international law-based multilateral world order.

We are capable of learning as human beings and as mankind. We learn from our mistakes. We will get up, and we will do better. Let us do this.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Estonia for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Alar Karis, President of the Republic of Estonia, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Javier Gerardo Milei, President of the Argentine Republic

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Argentine Republic.

Mr. Javier Gerardo Milei, President of the Argentine Republic, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Javier Gerardo Milei, President of the Argentine Republic, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Milei (spoke in Spanish): Last year, I stood here in the same Assembly and presented a new direction in Argentina's foreign policy (see A/79/PV.8).

We maintained that a return to the ideals of freedom was imperative, to the immortal principles that uphold the dignity of life, liberty and property for all individuals under the law, and to the necessity for international cooperation to have as its very purpose ensuring them.

However, I warned that the United Nations had strayed from its true purpose in recent decades. The successful model of the United Nations, which spoke of the need for peace and victory and was founded on the cooperation of nation States, had been replaced by a model of supranational governance by international bureaucrats who seek to impose a particular way of life on the citizens of the world.

This is how we have gone from an organization that aimed to mediate peace among equals, to one that seeks to decide not only what each nation State should do, but also what each individual in the various corners of the planet should do. We believe in the original purpose of the Organization. We believe that there are global problems that must be resolved through dialogue and international cooperation. But to do so we must reject the overreach that often accompanies noble agendas. As we stated last year, we will never support the curtailment of individual commercial freedoms or the violation of the natural rights of citizens of Member States. For the past year and a half, we have voted accordingly.

I say this knowing that many do not share my views because, as I have always said, it is preferable to speak an uncomfortable truth than a comfortable lie. Along those lines, today I want to talk to the Assembly about a specific problem facing all modern countries. Currently, the world is grappling with a contradiction between the present and the future — a problem of a political, economic and philosophical nature, the answer to which will determine the fate of all humanity.

If we frame it in the terms of comfort and discomfort that I have proposed, the entire world seems stuck in the comfort of the present, ignoring the consequences this may have for the future. Since discomfort diminishes the votes and power of those who embrace it, leaders prefer to do everything in their power to maintain the inherited status quo, even at the cost of future consequences. They burn the future to keep the present warm.

Thus, modern States have entered a highly complex dynamic that is difficult to reverse, in which the incentives for both the population and politicians prioritize distributing today's wealth over generating the wealth of tomorrow. Decision-makers are constantly faced with the choice of either preserving the legacy entrusted to them or destroying it. This legacy can be accumulated wealth, productive capacity, laws or anything that contributes to the common good. Generally, if they burn their legacy, if they opt for comfort, they will reap great benefits in the present but suffer even greater future costs — in other words, to make use of their savings today and lose them for tomorrow.

However, if they hold on to their savings, they will preserve growth and prosperity for themselves and future generations. In other words, it is necessary to find a balance

so that bread today does not mean hunger tomorrow, thus guaranteeing a sustained increase in well-being — what economists call economic growth. This growth may sometimes feel slow and may even be momentarily halted, because progress is never linear, but it is precisely its long-term consistency that has systematically revolutionized the world and lifted billions out of poverty. The difference between zero growth and 2 per cent growth in the long term is the difference between stagnation and prosperity. Argentinians know a great deal about this, being the only country in the region that has not grown in the past 15 years.

On a legal level, the condition for growth is the sanctity of property and the free market, which is nothing other than free cooperation among equals. Without property rights there is no saving, without saving and the ability to exchange it freely there is no investment, and without investment there is no possible growth. But it is not in the individual interest of the politician to respect these principles, because it is precisely in the expansion of the State at the expense of citizens' freedoms that the politician gains power.

Thus, for the politician, it will always be profitable to sacrifice the future on the altar of the present. Consuming accumulated capital generates momentary well-being, and that momentary well-being generates votes. In exchange, a future of greater growth is being sacrificed, causing accumulated wealth to diminish over time.

The clearest manifestation of this is countries that exhibit a spree of increased public spending, since the State does not create wealth, but rather steals and destroys it. In such a system, the politician gains power in two ways: democratic legitimacy and more resources to spend. In other words, the politician has a double incentive to foster this intergenerational betrayal — because although everyone loses in the future, in the present, the politician, more than anyone, wins.

In this sense, if a great man is one who plants trees whose shade he knows he will never enjoy, the one who cuts down the trees others have planted to build his seat of power is a miserable and ultimately despicable man. This is the great evil and the great trap to which almost all nations are slowly succumbing, because when this process unfolds, growth stagnates, and when growth stagnates, the demand for redistribution intensifies. Then the populist politician shouts even louder, appealing to envy and resentment. The end result of this process is seeing helpless young people suffocated by the weight of a State they know is only there to exploit them.

Unfortunately, fiscal expansion, monetary expansion and the expansion of State power over that of individuals form a repeating pattern in all countries, especially those that make up the free world. But the problem is not only one of economic policy. We also see it when equality before the law is violated, or when the doors are opened indiscriminately to immigration for political reasons, contrary to the very nature of immigration. In this case, it would be a matter of invasion, and international cooperation agencies, of which the Organization is a part, are also not immune to this problem.

Over the years, the Organization has acquired functions foreign to its founding spirit. It has created layer upon layer of bodies, agencies and programmes, to the point of achieving a hypertrophy of administrations that are largely ineffective in solving the problems for which they were created. Thus, the responsibilities of the United Nations have increased, the contributions received from Member States have increased, and the tangible results that the Organization had to offer the world have decreased.

Adding to this cocktail of conflicting incentives is the fact that, unlike national leaders, no one in international organizations is truly held accountable for failing to resolve a problem. The juxtaposition of grand objectives and meagre results has eroded the prestige of this institution and others. The poor results of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development is a prime example of what I am describing. What persists in

practice is a cycle of recycled structures, multiplied resources and reprogrammed goals. For this reason, Argentina decided at the time to withdraw from this process because we saw this Agenda as a waste of scarce resources for purposes we did not share, and with the effect of distracting attention from the real difficulties of a world heading towards stagnation. It is my duty to warn against this problem because in Argentina we lived through its natural consequence. We have reached the end of the comfortable path that comes from ignoring the future.

In other words, we come from a future that, for those gathered here, has not arrived yet. I want to tell them that they still have time to prevent it, because no society can survive if it burns the future to warm the present. In my country, we have learned a very valuable lesson the hard way. For decades, future cash flows were mortgaged to distribute stock in the present.

In 2023, we finally reached the point of 100 consecutive years of doing things wrong, of passing the bill from hand to hand until no one was left to pay it. And all of that, added to what I mentioned previously, ended up bankrupting our State. As a result of that implosion, for the past year and a half, we have had the enormous task of managing extreme scarcity. Today, for the first time in decades, we are doing what needs to be done to make the future better.

The only way to do this is to do the opposite of what was done in the past. This is countered by the rest of the political landscape, which demands that we do the same things they did, things that also dragged us into decline: mortgaging the future to satisfy present demands. They want us to apply what they did a thousand times over and what brought us to this point. But I want to make it clear that Argentina today has a Government that has decided to take the right path, even if it is the most difficult — because the prosperity and progress of our people can no longer be postponed.

However, we are not the only ones making the difficult decisions that this historic moment demands. President Trump in the United States of America also understands that it is time to reverse a trend that was leading the country to catastrophe, and we know that a catastrophe in the United States of America is a global catastrophe. His firm and successful policy, in terms of curbing illegal immigration, makes this abundantly clear. He understands that he must do what is necessary, even if many do not like it, before it is too late.

In other countries, for example, it is already too late for this decision. President Trump is also carrying out an unprecedented restructuring of the terms of international trade. This is a task of titanic proportions that goes to the heart of the global economic system, because this system was devastating the industrial heartland of his country and plunging it into an unparalleled debt crisis. Moreover, he is purging the institutional capture of the American State, because leftist factions had infiltrated it, undermining any reform programme, however necessary. These kinds of challenges that both President Trump and I are addressing have a common denominator that all countries of the world, and even supranational organizations, must confront. They must find a way to rekindle an interest in the future and not succumb to the temptation of only attending to the present. This is something that the great nations of the West practised for a long time, and we need to recover it.

We need to return to the basics. We must recover a sense of priority, along with a commitment to doing what is difficult and right over what is easy and comfortable, as I said before. This is also true for the various international organizations that have been gradually incorporating this approach into their ecosystems. I think I speak for everyone when I say that we would like the United Nations to lead this paradigm shift, returning to the principles that made it the great Organization it once was.

Therefore, I would humbly like to offer the Assembly four principles that we believe can be useful in pursuing this objective.

The first principle is that of an essential mandate. The central mission of the United Nations is to preserve international peace and security. Everything else must be conceived as complementary to that end. The strategic management of this institution's resources, therefore, requires adherence to these priorities, not others.

The second principle is that of international subsidiarity. The United Nations should intervene on an issue only when it is evident that the problem demonstrably exceeds national capacities for action. In all other cases, the initiative should be returned to the States, which possess democratic legitimacy and are accountable to their people.

The third principle is that of institutional efficiency. Just as Argentina has initiated a process of optimizing the State, eliminating redundant structures and returning resources to taxpayers, we understand that the United Nations needs a similar path. This implies conducting reliable audits, closing ineffective programmes, consolidating single agencies and providing funding conditioned on verifiable results.

The fourth principle is that of simplification and regulatory rationalization. Peace is not merely the absence of conflict; it requires prosperous societies. International cooperation must not become an obstacle to economic growth and the creation of opportunities. Therefore, we should only support initiatives that do not restrict the capacity of States to unleash their productive forces, attract investment and promote trade, which are the most successful paths to poverty reduction.

We believe these four principles would be invaluable in guiding the Organization to help it endure and deliver tangible results over time.

In conclusion, I would like to reiterate four sensitive and vitally important issues for the Argentine Republic.

First, I want to reaffirm our legitimate and inalienable claim to sovereignty over the Malvinas Islands, the South Georgia Islands and the South Sandwich Islands, and the surrounding maritime areas that remain illegally occupied. Despite the 80 years that have passed since the creation of the Organization, colonial situations like this remain unresolved. Therefore, we invite the United Kingdom to resume bilateral negotiations in accordance with General Assembly resolution 2065 (XX), along with all subsequent resolutions.

Secondly, I wish to reiterate my condemnation of the expressions of fundamentalist violence that still exist and are spreading throughout the world. In Argentina, we already suffered this horror with the attacks on the Israeli Embassy in 1992 and the Argentine Israeli Mutual Association in 1994. Therefore, we urge the international community to strengthen legal cooperation to ensure that INTERPOL Red Notices are respected and that those responsible for these atrocities are brought to justice, helping us to finally heal this painful wound in our country's history.

Thirdly, we are witnessing an unacceptable escalation of political violence by the left globally — violence that we in Argentina know all too well. It is unacceptable to resort to force where reason fails. For this reason, we emphatically condemn these actions, which violate the basic norms of democratic coexistence.

Fourthly, I recall the situation of Argentine citizen Nahuel Gallo, kidnapped and arbitrarily detained in Venezuela, without charges, without legal or consular assistance — in other words, an enforced disappearance. We demand his immediate release from the Venezuelan Government and call on the international community to support this legitimate demand in defence of the most basic principles of international law and human dignity.

Finally, we reiterate our demand for the immediate release of the hostages still held captive in Gaza. Finally, may God bless the free world, and may the power of heaven be with us.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Argentine Republic for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Javier Gerardo Milei, President of the Argentine Republic, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Aleksandar Vučić, President of the Republic of Serbia

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Serbia.

Mr. Aleksandar Vučić, President of the Republic of Serbia, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Aleksandar Vučić, President of the Republic of Serbia, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Vučić: I am very honoured to address the General Assembly at this eightieth anniversary session on behalf of the Republic of Serbia, a founding member of the United Nations and a freedom- and peace-loving country that is proud of its history.

This year, we mark eight decades of the existence of the world Organization. During that period, the United Nations has provided a framework for dialogue, cooperation and solidarity among the nations, without which it would not be possible to respond to the challenges of our day. Only through joint efforts can we create a future of security and dignity.

This brings me to the five essential principles that guide Serbia in its foreign-policy vision and constitute pillars in its international actions.

First, the United Nations is not a relic of the past; it is a compass for the future. Eighty years on, this is a moment for reflection, but also for candour. The United Nations should not be a stage where giants wrestle while smaller countries hold their breath. It should be a round table where every seat counts. Countries like ours — countries that belong to the global South — are too often treated as chess pieces. It is time to show that we can be conveners, innovators and guarantors of cooperation.

We may not have the loudest voice, but we often have the clearest vision — because we see both the East and West at once. Our engagement with all partners does not mean blind agreement. It means respect for sovereignty, territorial integrity and the belief that dialogue is stronger than division. Serbia is a reliable, predictable partner, but reciprocity matters. We will defend our autonomy as firmly as we defend cooperation.

The Charter of the United Nations was not written to serve one moment in history; it was written to withstand the tests of time. In a world facing deep geopolitical fractures, the Charter remains the only framework capable of holding us together.

Serbia is not a buffer zone; it is a bridge. And bridges connect; they do not divide. Therefore, as the President of Serbia, for the first time, I would like to offer Belgrade as a place of dialogue for all conflicts around the world. I believe that we will offer the best possible hospitality and absolute security for all participants.

The world is facing its deadliest surge in violence since the Second World War. In 2024, 61 armed conflicts erupted across 36 countries, the highest number in more than

seven decades. The proliferation of misinformation, particularly via digital platforms, has fuelled distrust between countries, targeting elections, trade negotiations and public sentiment. Serbia believes in pragmatic cooperation: finding common ground even where disagreements persist. People around the world are frustrated with governments and businesses, and they want a better future for themselves and their families. The best way to deliver that is through collaboration across nations.

We live in times of the most difficult conflicts and the most difficult divisions within countries, continents and regions since the foundation of the United Nations. It is particularly worrisome that, triggered by different factors, we now have the deepest and the most difficult divisions within each society, with, most often, extremely violent consequences of actions of mutual non-understanding, non-communication and distancing from what used to be accepted as elementary decency and behaviour, in both country-to-country and people-to-people relations.

The world is divided — believe it or not — less by ideological, but much more by emotional, hate-driven differences, caused by undermining of countries, societies and elementary moral values. In each village and hamlet worldwide, and particularly with the members of the citizens alleged elite — at least it used to be the case — no matter who dies of natural causes, and especially if someone dies in an accident or gets killed, the majority of society, even those who did not think highly of the respective person during his or her lifetime, felt the need to pay their respect to the deceased.

Today, we are witnessing an unprecedented wonder — a sick expression of joy for a crime committed against an innocent person. The example of Charlie Kirk is the best confirmation of that. He was savagely assassinated just because his killer did not like his ideas. He was shot even after death by the same people who had prepared political and media grounds for his assassination. Do not be surprised that I am speaking about this more than about global conflicts; it is precisely because such a development devastates in the deepest and clearest way the global political community much more than conflicts with clear and visible actors.

In the era of social networks, in the era of freedom, we have reached the point of the biggest unfreedoms and unambiguous limiting of freedoms of others. How is it possible that an ABC Television Network host gets more media attention in the United States than the attempted assassination of President Trump? Who are these shadow rulers who impact the key political movements and who want to run the world and each country individually, and, almost as a rule, without the people’s will and legitimacy? They run all the processes and all of us because they are chosen by God — as they like to put it — the elite and not the people who are, I suppose, incapable of choosing their own path. Those are extremely dangerous things, which would lead to further dissolving our societies, our countries and world politics, as a whole.

A great deal has been said here about Palestine and Israel. Both are our friends. I cannot easily take sides and speak about good and bad people merely in order to secure more “likes” on social networks or to score points in daily politics. Speaking of which, let me return to the beginning of this part of my speech. Big pro-Palestinian demonstrations were held in Italy during the past weekend. People were shouting “Gaza, Gaza”, but, at least in Milan, some of them did not even think of Gaza. The only thing that was on their mind was demolishing and burning down what the Italian people had created for centuries, just because it is popular to be against the Government and take part in some kind of violence. When the otherwise very composed Italian Prime Minister, Giorgia Meloni, rightly calls such hooligans “thugs”, we all ask ourselves what the next stage would be like and what awaits us in the future.

During the past months, Serbia was facing unrest and attacks against the constitutional order. In spite of the violence exerted by the protesters, I tried to find a

significant share of blame in myself, ourselves, and in us running the country. I wanted to listen, and I understood the message of the people in the streets. That is why, just like here at the United Nations, I believe that dialogue between the nations and countries has no alternative. I offered dialogue, an unconditioned discussion on all the topics of significance for our society, to people who think differently, and I am absolutely certain that in the upcoming period we will overcome all the difficulties from the past months.

Progress on global challenges is uneven: financing is dwindling, the United Nations budget is constrained, and smaller nations often lack access to the tools and support that richer countries enjoyed, particularly in the energy transition. Climate change is not just a statistic for Serbia and the Balkans; it is a lived reality, marked by droughts, floods and energy insecurity.

Sustainable economic growth is essential, not optional, for climate resilience and well-being. For us, partnerships are defined by commitment, not hierarchy. We are a place where the East and West collaborate on concrete projects, from clean energy to infrastructure and digital transformation. We will continue to build on this foundation. At a time when the United Nations seeks to inspire trust globally, these practical, results-driven partnerships strengthen confidence at home and abroad.

Alongside many other Member States, especially those who do not belong among great Powers, Serbia is adamant in pointing to the importance of, and respect for, the fundamental principles and rules of the Charter of the United Nations. Perhaps it is only too proper to repeat today what we committed to eight decades ago: the principles and rules of the Charter are valid equally for all States, large or small, for all political Powers or levels of development.

With a feeling of deep pride, my country continues to commit to a consistent implementation of international norms notwithstanding the fact that it, too, is facing a lack of fairness and double standards. In words and deeds, and on a number of occasions, Serbia has recommitted to respecting the sovereignty and territorial integrity of all Member States, the fundamental principles of the Charter. In doing so, my country expects all States to respect its sovereignty and territorial integrity, which, I have the pleasure to note, most of them do and to which I owe my profound gratitude. After all, as I have said on many previous occasions, the respect of the Charter is not a matter of choice, rather it is a universal and binding obligation on us all.

Secondly, territorial integrity is not a principle measured by power; it is the measure that restrains power. If the principle of territorial integrity is applied selectively, it ceases to apply at all. Its violation in one place becomes justification for conflict everywhere. Undermining it does not create exceptions. Instead, like in the case of Serbia, it creates precedents — dangerous ones.

Serbia is well aware of the price paid in disregard of international law and multilateralism. Twenty-six years ago, my country fell prey to a brutal aggression by NATO. It opened a Pandora’s box of sorts whereby the very postulates of international law were unscrupulously undermined and the principle of territorial integrity brought into question.

The consequences of such actions by those who considered themselves untouchable at the time are felt today as well. Even though small compared to global Powers, Serbia is not dissuaded from commitment to the principles of international law. We firmly believe that they should be respected in every situation, without exception and selectivity. As a persistent drop can shape stones over time, so too can our perseverance in defending universal norms help to assert their durability.

Serbia will continue advocating for those principles, as their observance is the only reliable way to peace and stability. This rostrum and this occasion are the best

opportunity to reiterate that my country will never forget its history, its people and its sanctities. Kosovo and Metohija is an inseparable part of Serbia, the main pillar of its identity, culture and spiritual heritage. For us Serbs, it is not only a piece of land, it is the cradle of our spirituality and our existence on that land over centuries.

Our concern is not only moral and historical, but also humane. It is with a heavy heart that I speak of the tragic circumstances in which the Serbs of Kosovo and Metohija live today. Day in and day out, they are denied basic human rights: the right to life, freedom of movement, education, health protection, access to workplaces and property. They live in isolation, basic foods and medicines are in short supply, and children grow up in fear and uncertainty. Their situation is not only local. It calls upon the conscience of the entire international community and is a test of its readiness to fend for the innocent and helpless.

We witness ethnic violence suffered by the Serbs almost every day. It is frightening in size and scope. The Serbs are physically attacked, intimidated and arrested unlawfully. Their property is confiscated and their rights to language, education and cultural expression limited. The Serbs are often discriminated against as well; the practice sets the stage to make life in Serbian communities more difficult, as they are denied basic services, taxed exorbitantly and face erected hurdles and obstacles. This is aimed at creating fear and pressure and, by extension, change the demographic picture and force the Serbs to flee Kosovo and Metohija.

Serbia, therefore, calls on the international community to take concrete and resolute measures to stop the violence in order to ensure the security and rights of all peoples in Kosovo and Metohija. Compassion is not good enough; we need deeds and protection mechanisms.

Notwithstanding the continuous, open and obvious violations of Security Council resolution 1244 (1999), Serbia continues to believe in dialogue under the auspices of the European Union. It has no alternative and, if true and committed, it is the only way to a just and sustainable solution in line with international law and with full respect for mutual obligations. Just as in the past, my country will continue to fight for peace patiently, emphatically and in good faith.

Thirdly, the Balkans must not be a stage for the ambitions of others, but a space for shared responsibility. Thirty years after the conflict, stability has become our highest value. The nations of the Balkans deserve the right to shape their future free from external patronage, through cooperation, mutual respect and regional ownership.

Cooperation, dialogue and mutual confidence are also perceived as main levers of international relations on the regional level. We believe that our region should look to the future while we continue to work to the benefit of all citizens and economic interlinkage. To paraphrase Indira Gandhi who once said that one cannot shake hands with a clenched fist, let me say that Serbia will keep its hand extended, reaching over divisions and borders, devoted to stability and prosperity for all those who strive for a positive agenda and a vision of a common European future.

The stability of our region is of paramount importance for us. As a guarantor of the General Framework Agreement for Peace in Bosnia and Herzegovina and the Annexes thereto, which we signed 30 years ago, we shall always work towards its full implementation and respect for the rights of all three constituent peoples in Bosnia and Herzegovina: Serbs, Bosnians and Croats. Unilateral acts and the abuse of authority contrary to the letter of the Agreement are not conducive to peace, and they bring about new tensions. Only by the agreement of Bosnia and Herzegovina’s peoples and entities can the stability and functioning of that country be guaranteed.

The absence of dialogue and unilateral initiatives without the agreement of all interested sides, in particular the initiatives that take advantage of international organizations, are but a step back to a painful past and create new divisions. Serbia will use all diplomatic means to prevent these activities from taking place as they undermine regional dialogue, the process of reconciliation and understanding. We shall not hesitate in our resolve to promote regional stability in an effort to contribute to global security.

For exactly 30 years now, in this institution and everywhere else, a false campaign has been ongoing against both the Republic of Serbia and Republika Srpska, the entity within Bosnia and Herzegovina. All over the world, everywhere, countless times, one could hear — from well-informed sources, as they use to say — how it was only a matter of days before Serbia would attack someone in the region, and that Republika Srpska and its leadership would violate the territorial integrity of Bosnia and Herzegovina.

All this time, it has been a lie, a real smokescreen intended to enable international representatives who are not elected by the people to deal with legitimate representatives of the Serbian people — one of the three constituent peoples in Bosnia and Herzegovina — imposing sanctions against them, replacing them from the positions the people elected them to, believe it or not, conducting criminal proceedings against them and issuing convictions for words spoken, for verbal offences.

For 3.5 years, since the beginning of the conflict in Ukraine, Member States have all been witnesses. They have been hearing stories that we, as an alleged Russian puppet, will attack someone in the region, which, of course, did not happen and will not happen. The only thing we have never heard is an apology from those who spread such falsehoods, and it is quite certain that we will never hear one.

Let me reiterate: Serbia is a free, independent and sovereign country that makes its own decisions independently. We are committed to our European path; we do not plan to attack anyone, but we will also not allow anyone else to threaten our freedom and our country.

Fourthly, the world is changing, and the United Nations must evolve to remain a pillar of global stability. Reforming the United Nations is not simply an institutional task, it is a moral duty to safeguard the future of global peace and justice. We are well aware of the need to reform the United Nations and revitalize its system in order to increase its credibility and shore up multilateralism so as to make our Organization more effective, just and close to the needs of its Member States. Moreover, the Security Council should become more effective in, and better adapted to, the pursuit of its primary goal of safeguarding international peace in order to reflect more accurately the reality of the present-day world. Africa, in particular, the youngest continent, which comprises 54 States, must be better represented.

Many countries rely on the United Nations for technical expertise, development funding and guidance to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals. Cuts to funding or reduced access to United Nations programmes risk widening the gap between wealthy and developing nations. As the United Nations looks for ways to reduce costs, we are happy to offer to host any United Nations bodies, institutions and agencies in Serbia, with the best possibility to continue being a bridge between developed and developing regions. Serbia is situated at the crossroads of Europe, easily accessible to both the East and West. Speaking about cost-effectiveness, we are able to offer lower operational costs compared with Geneva, New York or other big hubs.

Belgrade offers modern facilities, reliable connectivity and proven capacity to host large international events, for example Expo 2027. Hosting an agency in Belgrade strengthens the presence of the United Nations in South-Eastern Europe, a region with transitional and developmental experience relevant to global priorities. This would

expand the Organization's geographic footprint, ensuring agencies are more representative and globally distributed.

Fifthly, Serbia will remain independent and will overcome internal challenges through the strength of its statehood tradition, focusing steadfastly on building a prosperous future. True sovereignty today is not insulation. It is the dignity to choose, to say yes on our own terms and to use that choice for cooperation. Serbia's independence is not a privilege granted; it is a sovereign right exercised. And its sovereignty is not situational, it is foundational.

Notwithstanding numerous global challenges, Serbia has remained on a steady course: its macroeconomic situation is stable and its economy continues to grow, which only shows how commitment to reforms and responsible economic policies lead to great results. Investments in infrastructure, energy transition and digitalization bear out my country's commitment to sustainable development and the Sustainable Development Goals of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

Let me take a moment to inform the Assembly that in 2027, Serbia will host the specialized exhibition Expo 2027. With the motto "Play for humanity: sport and music for all", this event will provide an opportunity for my country to show the world the strength of our culture, sport and creativity as a universal language that transcends differences. This will be a moment in which Serbia, along with its partners, will build bridges of friendship and togetherness, promote understanding and open new horizons of cooperation.

Serbia's way is the way of development, progress and prosperity. And it is fully committed to becoming a full-fledged member of the European Union. This commitment, though, makes us no less devoted to promoting and deepening cooperation with countries from other parts of the world, while maintaining and cherishing our traditional friendships and relations of trust in the East.

Strengthening overall bilateral relations with key actors of the international community and with our European partners is at the top of our agenda. In the past several years, Serbia has also raised the level of cooperation with numerous countries in Africa, Asia and Latin America, thus playing a respectable role on the global stage. I trust and believe that we can count on mutual respect and the traditional bonds of friendship with those countries in our future relations.

In conclusion, looking to the future and committed to dialogue and understanding, we in Serbia believe that peace is the highest value and the most solid foundation of development. We shall continue to invest our energies, knowledge and will in building a world that is more just, secure and worthy of the coming generations.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Serbia for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Aleksandar Vučić, President of the Republic of Serbia, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Ahmad Al-Sharaa, President of the Syrian Arab Republic

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Syrian Arab Republic.

Mr. Ahmad Al-Sharaa, President of the Syrian Arab Republic, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Ahmad Al-Sharaa, President of the Syrian Arab Republic, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Al-Sharaa (*spoke in Arabic*): The Syrian story is filled with emotions, and it mixes pain with hope. The Syrian story is a story of struggle between good and evil, and between right, which is weak and has no supporter except God, and wrong, which is strong and has all the tools for killing and destruction. Our story is one of the lessons of history, and it is an embodiment of noble human meanings and values. In this eternal struggle between right and wrong, we find a new chapter of the Syrian story, one recounting a brilliant and creative struggle, filled with determination, patience, torture, pain and sacrifice, clinging on to noble customs, values, hard work and reliance on God — tools to promote right over wrong.

I come to the Assembly from Damascus, the capital of history and the cradle of civilizations, from a beautiful country that has taught the world the meaning of civilization and the value of human beings and peaceful coexistence, to be a beacon for the world. However, for 60 years Syria fell under a repressive rule that disregarded the value of the territory it ruled over and repressed a kind and peaceful people.

Mr. Arafa (Lebanon), Vice-President, took the Chair.

For long years, our people suffered injustice, deprivation, and oppression. Then they rose up, clamouring for freedom and dignity. They were met with killings, torture, fire, rape, and displacement. The previous regime used the worst kind of torture against our people — chemical weapons, bombardment, torture in prison, displacement, sectarian strife and drugs — against our people and the world. It tore our country apart and destroyed its most important historical sites. It brought in foreign forces — militias, gangs and fighters from around the world — and took our beautiful country hostage. The former regime killed approximately 1 million people, tortured hundreds of thousands, displaced nearly 14 million people and demolished close to 2 million homes with their inhabitants still inside.

The weak people were targeted with chemical weapons in more than 200 documented attacks. Our women, children and youth inhaled toxic gases in more than 200 documented attacks. The regime did all this to silence the voice of truth. With all this criminality, the regime rejected any political language for a solution, despite the offers. The people had no choice but to organize and prepare for a great historic confrontation through a swift military operation that dismantled a criminal system that had lasted 60 years, along with all its backers. The military operation was filled with mercy and good. It prioritized forgiveness and tolerance. This military battle did not displace anyone and did not target or kill any civilians. It culminated in a victory with no vengeance or hatred.

The people reclaimed their rights and avenged the wrongs done to them . We were victorious in the battle for those who were wronged, tortured and forcibly displaced. We were victorious for the mothers of martyrs and the disappeared and for all the peoples of the world, for the future of our children and theirs.

We paved the way for the return of refugees, and we eradicated the drug trafficking from our country to others under the previous regime. With this victory, Syria has ceased to be an exporter of crisis and has become a historic opportunity for stability, peace and prosperity in the country and the region.

This unique Syrian achievement and the solidarity among our people have led certain actors to try and instigate sectarianism and in-fighting to once again divide and tear apart our country. But the Syrian people had enough self-awareness to prevent calamity and avoid casting the country back to square one.

The Syrian State set up fact-finding commissions and granted permission to United Nations fact-finding missions. These commissions produced similar conclusions with unprecedented transparency. I pledge to bring to justice anyone with innocent blood

on their hands. In the same context, Israeli threats against my country have continued from 6 December 2024 to this very day. Israeli policies run counter to the international position of support for Syria and its people. Israel seeks to exploit the transition phase, which threatens a new cycle of crises and struggles in our region, with no end in sight.

In this regard, Syria has sought to promote dialogue and diplomacy to emerge from the crisis and is committed to the 1974 Agreement on Disengagement between Israeli and Syrian Forces. We call on the international community to stand beside us in the face of these threats and ensure the respect of Syria's territorial integrity.

From the very moment the former regime fell, we set out a clear policy built upon several pillars: balanced diplomacy, security and stability, and economic development. We filled the power vacuum, called for an inclusive national dialogue and announced a Government of competence. We strengthened the principle of participation and established the National Commission for Transitional Justice and the National Commission for Missing Persons, thereby ensuring justice and fairness.

We are now preparing to elect representatives of the people in the People's Assembly. We restructured civil and military institutions, dissolving all previous formations under the principle of restricting arms to State authorities. Through intensive diplomatic activity, Syria restored its international relations and forged regional and global partnerships. It worked towards the gradual lifting of most sanctions. We call now for the complete lifting of sanctions, so that they no longer shackle the Syrian people. Investment laws have been amended, and major regional and international companies have already begun entering the Syrian market, contributing through investment in reconstruction.

Syria today is rebuilding itself through the establishment of a new State, building institutions and laws that guarantee the rights of all, without exception. A land of ancient civilization and culture deserves to be a State of law that protects everyone, safeguards their rights, guarantees their freedoms and promotes their prosperity while it turns the page on a wretched past. We are determined to restore our country's glory, dignity and honour.

In continuation of the Syrian story, I declare before the Assembly today the triumph of right over wrong. In the words of the Qu'ran: "Say 'truth has arrived, and falsehood perished; for falsehood is bound to perish.'"

Syria is today reclaiming its rightful place among the nations of the world. This announcement is the echo of a great people's will — a people who forged glory throughout the ages, who rose again from beneath the rubble to restore their rights, freedom and dignity.

On behalf of the Syrian people, I extend my gratitude to everyone who championed the Syrian cause, who aided Syrians in overcoming their tragedy and who welcomed them in their countries, and to all nations' peoples who rejoiced in the victory of the Syrian people's will and now stand with them in the march for peace and prosperity. I particularly thank Türkiye, Qatar, the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia and all Arab and Islamic States, as well as the United States of America and the European Union.

Before I conclude, let me affirm that we wish upon no one the suffering our country endured. We are among the peoples most deeply aware of the horrors of war and destruction. For that reason, we stand firmly with the people of Gaza, its children and women and all peoples facing violations and aggression. We call for an immediate end to the war.

In conclusion, the Syrian story has not come to an end. It continues to write a new chapter entitled "Peace, prosperity and development".

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Syrian Arab Republic for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Ahmad Al-Sharaa, President of the Syrian Arab Republic, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Zoran Milanović, President of the Republic of Croatia

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Croatia.

Mr. Zoran Milanović, President of the Republic of Croatia, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Zoran Milanović, President of the Republic of Croatia, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Milanović: For Croatia, the United Nations has always been a core, essential global institution. During our own struggle for independence, sovereignty, recognition and territorial integrity, the United Nations played a decisive role.

Our path to admission and early years of membership were about braving the stormy seas rather than smooth sailing, and it was the Organization and what it represents — the principles of the Charter of the United Nations — that served as our safe harbour. I believe this experience proved productive for both Croatia and the United Nations and has provided many lessons for the future, including on how to successfully end a complex war and conduct peaceful territorial integration and reintegration.

Today, the international community faces daunting challenges. Armed conflicts are more numerous than at any time since the Second World War. They are multiplying and intensifying, overwhelming humanitarian systems and eroding trust in our capacity to prevent or resolve crises. In Ukraine, we hope the senseless loss of human lives will end as soon as possible. We welcome recent diplomatic efforts and encourage inclusive dialogue that can restore peace.

Beyond Europe, other regions face devastating crises. In Gaza, tens of thousands of women and children — human beings — have been killed, and more continue to be killed. Millions live without safety, food, medicine and basic human dignity. This is worse than a mere war. It is carnage, and we urgently call for it to end, for the safe delivery of aid, especially to children, and for the release of all hostages. Lasting peace can come only through the universal recognition of the legitimate political aspirations of the Palestinian people, long denied. It is time to close the chapter.

The suffering in less visible crises is no less real. In the Sudan, one of the gravest humanitarian catastrophes of the twenty-first century is unfolding before our eyes.

United Nations peacekeeping must adapt to today’s conflicts. Missions must be flexible, realistic and sequenced towards achievable and reasonable goals. This requires the Security Council to focus on political solutions and remain committed to sustaining peace long after missions withdraw. Peace is more than silencing the guns. It requires preventing new wars and breaking cycles of violence from the past. Lasting peace rests on democracy, legitimate governance and full respect for the right of each people to freely choose their leaders and representatives.

In our region of South-Eastern Europe, Croatia continues to champion and promote legitimate political processes as the foundation of progress. European Union membership is not a cure-all, but it remains a strong driver of prosperity, as can be witnessed in my country, Croatia. We promote good neighbourly relations and urge all countries to refrain from actions that undermine stability in the region.

In Bosnia and Herzegovina, we call for full respect of the constitutional order, sovereignty and equality of the three constituent peoples. All parties and the international community must uphold the General Framework Agreement for Peace in Bosnia and Herzegovina. Respecting the right of constituent peoples to choose their legitimate political representatives at all levels of government is a fundamental prerequisite of lasting stability and progress in European Bosnia and Herzegovina.

Lasting peace cannot be imposed; it must be built. If it is to be sustainable, it must include respect for human rights and development that is inclusive and fair — basic building blocks of any just and prosperous society.

The humanitarian system must be reformed to respond with speed, innovation and stronger partnerships with local actors. Croatia supports the Organization's humanitarian reset in order to make responses more agile, effective and grounded in resilience. Above all, strict respect for international humanitarian law must remain the moral core of multilateralism.

In Croatia, over three decades after the Homeland War, families are still searching for 1,744 missing loved ones — not bodies, not just numbers, but human souls: fathers, sons and grandchildren still missing, unaccounted for. As co-Chair of the Global Alliance for the Missing, Croatia draws on its painful experience to raise the global visibility of this issue, share good practices and strengthen cooperation. Survivor-centred justice is enshrined in our laws in Croatia, and we encourage others to follow this path.

We also share the Croatian model for searching for the missing. It rests on effective interdepartmental cooperation and a comprehensive, transparent approach without discrimination, consistent with the highest international standards, some of which have been set by us. With this in mind, Croatia is proud to host later today a high-level side event on missing persons in armed conflict, dedicated to advancing the search for answers.

Another legacy of the Homeland War is the issue of landmines. Croatia has been active in promoting the Human Rights Council's first resolution on landmines (Human Rights Council resolution 58/22), adopted by consensus on 4 April, the International Day for Mine Awareness and Assistance in Mine Action. The resolution reaffirms the treaty banning anti-personnel mines and sends a clear message: the needless cruelty of these weapons violates basic human rights and the notion of humanity.

The togetherness that is promoted throughout this debate especially means inclusion of the most vulnerable. Therefore, Croatia is proud to have led the initiative resulting in the consensus adoption with an impressive 99 Member States co-sponsoring the resolution 79/294, declaring 27 June as the International Day of Deafblindness.

Peace and security are inseparable from development and human rights. The founders of the United Nations acknowledged this when they placed these three pillars at the heart of the Organization. As we mark the tenth anniversary of the General Assembly's resolution on the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, Croatia reaffirms its commitment to the Sustainable Development Goals and to ensuring that no one is left behind.

We are grateful to Member States for their support in electing Croatia to the Economic and Social Council for the 2026–2028 term. Our priorities will include accelerating the 2030 Agenda, preparing momentum for the 2027 Sustainable Development Goals Summit and the Agenda beyond 2030, and strengthening links between humanitarian, development and peace efforts.

At home, in Croatia, sustainable development is fully embedded in our national planning. Croatia's National Development Strategy 2030 is closely aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals, placing us among leading global performers.

We reaffirm our commitment to progress made at meetings of the Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, including the landmark twenty-eighth Conference of the Parties agreement to begin phasing out fossil fuels; the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties, in Baku, where it was agreed to deliver on a new quantified climate financing goal; and the thirtieth Conference of the Parties, in Belém, Brazil, where it was agreed to raise our ambitions, advance the transition from fossil fuels and scale up climate financing. Croatia supports a credible climate financing road map.

The triple planetary crisis also threatens global public health. Croatia endorses the One Health approach, recognizing the interdependence of human, animal and environmental health. We welcome the adoption of the Pandemic Agreement at the seventy-eight World Health Assembly earlier this year.

As a Mediterranean nation, Croatia knows that healthy seas are both a national imperative and a global responsibility. We remain committed to multilateral ocean protection under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea. We welcome the outcome of the third United Nations Ocean Conference in Nice, France, have ratified the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction and urge others to do so without unnecessary delay.

Croatia's contributions to development cooperation and humanitarian aid continue to grow. Since 2011, we have steadily increased our support, reaching record levels in 2023. We share lessons from our own recovery — from democratic transition to mine action and veteran reintegration. In Ukraine, our expertise in humanitarian demining is particularly valued, making us one of the leading contributors relative to gross domestic product. Our support extends far beyond our neighbourhood, reaching all of South-Eastern Europe, the Eastern and Southern neighbourhoods and Africa.

The fundamental changes we are witnessing in our world are not a mere historical echo but an all-encompassing global transformation: we are at a defining moment of an era to come. Emerging technologies are reshaping every aspect of society — how we live, how we trade and how we defend ourselves. Drones are a clear example. They have not only increased the lethality of war; they have changed its economics. They have shown us that assumptions we held only a decade ago about defence and deterrence are already outdated — total bygones.

This disruption brings danger, but also opportunity. New tools can be misused by hostile actors, spreading instability and lowering the threshold for conflict. Yet the same tools, used responsibly, can strengthen our defences, improve disaster response and drive economic growth. Artificial intelligence, cybercapabilities, space technologies and robotics — each can be a threat or a solution. The choice is ours.

We need to rethink security — not only nationally but globally. Rules, safeguards and cooperation must keep pace with innovation. If they do not, we risk instability and peril; if they do, these technologies can become engines of resilience and stability. The task is urgent. The world must act with clarity, not hesitation. Emerging technologies are not tomorrow's challenge; they are today's reality. How we choose to guide them will define not just the future of defence but also the future of peace.

Reforming the United Nations is an existential necessity. At 80, the United Nations must adapt to stay relevant and effective. We welcome the Secretary-General's UN80 Initiative as an opportunity not only to celebrate achievements but also to reform and

revitalize the Organization. The Security Council remains essential and its reform is fundamental. The Council must become more inclusive, effective, transparent and accountable. Croatia supports comprehensive reform, including enlargement in both categories of membership and stronger representation of underrepresented regions, in particular Africa.

The financial stability of the United Nations is also vital. All Member States must pay their dues — their contributions — in full, on time and without conditions. Without predictable financing, mandates fail and trust weakens. The upcoming review of the United Nations peacebuilding architecture offers another chance to turn commitments into action. Croatia will contribute actively, emphasizing prevention, coherence and strong links between peace, development and human rights. We welcome the decision to provide assessed contributions for the Peacebuilding Fund from 2025, but needs still outpace resources.

The United Nations does not exist for itself, but to serve humanity: to save and improve lives, protect dignity and freedoms and advance peace, security and sustainable development. On its eightieth anniversary, we have a duty to leave to future generations a United Nations system that is stronger, not weaker. Croatia will continue to defend the principles of the Charter and international law — not the rules-based order — to support multilateral solutions and to build partnerships rooted in respect and responsibility. The world is not short of strategies and grand ideas, reports or debates. What it lacks is political courage and determination. Let us find that courage together and prove that multilateralism can meet this moment and rise to the challenges of our times.

The Acting President: On behalf of the Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Croatia for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Zoran Milanović, President of the Republic of Croatia, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Nikos Christodoulides, President of the Republic of Cyprus

The Acting President: The General Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Cyprus.

Mr. Nikos Christodoulides, President of the Republic of Cyprus, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Nikos Christodoulides, President of the Republic of Cyprus, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Christodoulides: We stand at the brink of a precipice. The international order, as we know it, is challenged in an unprecedented manner 80 years since the United Nations emerged from the Second World War. Today, we stand before drastic, unpredictable geopolitical shifts. Instability appears to spiral. An uncharted landscape seems resistant to the international order and norms as we know them. We are witnessing devastating wars and unimaginable humanitarian catastrophe and human suffering. Blatant violations of international law and international humanitarian law bring our system to its knees. We stand before the rise of the use of force against sovereign States, which constantly escalates and expands, threatening regional security and stability. States are sponsoring malign actors to destabilize, disrupting critical maritime routes. The use of new means of warfare is rising, without even the most basic safeguards in place. Global security is constantly being undermined.

At the same time, we face the challenge of the uncontrolled expansion of technology and artificial intelligence, threatening our security and the well-being of our children. Climate change is looming, threatening livelihoods and economies and

creating new migration routes. Inequalities are becoming embedded. Our world is changing rapidly. While there can be no doubt that the United Nations has served a noble cause and that, together, we have achieved tremendous progress, at this critical moment of inflection, we have a responsibility to recognize our shortcomings, to admit that we have lagged behind and that we have failed along the way. These admissions need to stir us to action. We must urgently evolve to be fit to effectively address the immense, complex challenges we face.

This is our moment of responsibility. Collective responsibility and individual State responsibility are inextricably linked and mutually reinforcing. The scale and nature of the challenges we face require both. “Better together” is the theme of this year’s Assembly. But beyond “better”, we are also stronger and more resilient together. This is the moment to renew our collective commitment and stand firmly and boldly in support of multilateralism and international law. Dialogue and diplomacy are the sole path to lasting stability and security — dialogue and diplomacy over violence, each and every time. Most importantly, this is the moment to transform pledges into bold action, into change. History will look back on this moment in time, and it will be unforgiving. It will judge us all, not by the declaratory statements we pronounce, but by the change we enable. We will be judged by the change we become, as States, as Governments and as leaders that have been elected by our citizens to deliver.

My country, Cyprus, walks this path of responsibility, and it stands ready to step up further, to further assume its role as an enabler of security and stability in the eastern Mediterranean and the greater Middle East. It acts as a driver of cooperation, underpinned by a vision of strength through partnership with like-minded countries, and as a safe harbour in turbulent waters. We are determined to transform our geography in a complex region into a blessing by building on our long-standing historical ties with our neighbours, which are anchored in trust, mutual respect and cooperation. We are always part of the solution to the region’s challenges, as a credible, reliable and responsible partner. We have proven this time and time again. Cyprus will always be a stable, trustworthy and safe harbour.

Let me be clear. This is not theoretical. It takes shape and form through concrete initiatives that build on Cyprus’ role as a hub of stability and cooperation in a challenging part of the world. Cyprus has consistently provided the necessary infrastructure and support for the evacuation of foreign nationals from areas of danger or conflict — from the Sudan, Lebanon, Israel and Iran. Following the barbaric Hamas terrorist attack of 7 October 2023 and the subsequent war that has led to a humanitarian tragedy in Gaza, Cyprus assumed, yet again, its moral responsibility to its region. We did so through the development of the Amalthea maritime corridor for the delivery of humanitarian assistance to the civilian population in Gaza. The route was reactivated as recently as this past week. We worked with like-minded partners — the United Arab Emirates, the United States, the European Union, the United Kingdom and others — and we delivered.

Furthermore, in the face of persecution in the region of religious and other minorities, Cyprus could not remain idle. Proving our long-standing commitment to upholding fundamental rights and freedoms, once again demonstrating responsibility, we appointed a special envoy for religious freedom and protection of minorities in the Middle East. At the same time, my country has responded to the calls of our neighbours for assistance in the face of fires, sending our brave firefighters as reinforcement. And our neighbours have reciprocated. Also, as part of our regional responsibility to address climate change, the initiative proposed by Cyprus and Jordan for a European firefighting hub in Cyprus, covering our region, is now on the path to implementation by the European Union. These examples are only a snapshot of Cyprus’ active, tangible

responsibility. I am very proud that my country walks this path of responsibility. We are determined to expand it, always being part of the solution, never part of the problem.

Cyprus also stands ready to assume its regional responsibility in the context of bringing an end to the war in Gaza and, given our proximity, to play a role in its reconstruction. Let me be clear: there are no substitutes for peace. This war must end. A first necessary step is the immediate ceasefire in Gaza, and I truly hope that President Trump's initiative has a positive outcome. At the same time, the humanitarian catastrophe must be alleviated. This means the unhindered flow of aid into Gaza. The displacement must also end. International humanitarian law must be respected. We also call, with the same fervour, for the immediate release of all hostages. As unreachable as it may seem at this moment, we must not lose sight of the path for peace, for a two-State solution in line with Security Council resolutions. We have a responsibility to continue our work for a future in which Israel and Palestine live side by side in conditions of lasting security and peace. We must be clear and unequivocal that Hamas, a terrorist organization, has no place in such a future.

As part of our responsibility, my country will assume the rotating presidency of the Council of the European Union in January 2026. The European Union has evolved into an unprecedented political union, embodying the essence of multilateralism, anchored in respect for the Charter of the United Nations. It is a project of collective responsibility that delivers — a unifying force of stability, security and prosperity. The European Union presidency is yet another moment of responsibility for Cyprus. Europe's heart will beat for six months from the Union's last divided member State, under occupation since the 1974 Turkish invasion. We will exercise our responsibility, fully aware of what is at stake: an imperative need to deliver stronger multilateralism, more integration and more cooperation between Europe and the world; to deliver a stronger, more secure and more autonomous Union. We are committed to supporting partners, also focusing on the eastern Mediterranean and the greater Middle East; supporting and investing in strategic partners that are pillars of stability in the region, such as Egypt and Jordan; working together with our Lebanese partners to ensure long-lasting stability in the country; working to ensure stability, inclusivity, respect for religious freedoms and, of course, protection of minorities in Syria; and assuming more responsibility as a Union for our security and for our neighbourhood.

Cyprus will assume another role of responsibility, for the first time in its history, as a member of the Human Rights Council for the period 2025–2027. It is in the same spirit that we also proudly presented our candidature for the presidency of the General Assembly at its eighty-first session, as a Member State that embodies and embraces the principles of multilateralism, inclusivity, bridge-building and, of course, responsibility.

The Russian aggression against Ukraine, in violation of the United Nations Charter, must serve as a wake-up call. As we condemn the use of force against a sovereign nation, the killing of civilians, the forced disappearance of children and the destruction and displacement, we have an obligation to remember that we must collectively act against aggressors, no matter who they are. Appeasement never yields results. History demonstrates this very clearly. Each time we turn a blind eye to violations of territorial integrity and the sovereignty of States anywhere in the world, we create the space and the opportunity for the next aggressor. This time, it could be any country.

In 2022, Russia invaded the sovereign nation of Ukraine, violating the United Nations Charter. In 1974, Türkiye invaded a sovereign nation, Cyprus, in violation of the United Nations Charter. The violation was equal, as were the suffering, the invasion and the occupation. My country, Cyprus, has been under occupation by Türkiye for 51 years. Tens of thousands have been displaced, women raped and cultural and religious heritage destroyed. The fenced town of Varosha is being held hostage by Türkiye, awaiting the return of its lawful inhabitants, as prescribed by the relevant Security

Council resolutions, and Türkiye must allow it. Türkiye has been pursuing a policy of illegal settlements aimed at changing the demographic character of the country. Families, 51 years later, are waiting to learn of the fate of their loved ones. As a young boy in those early years after the invasion, the images of mothers and children weeping for their loved ones have been engraved in my memory.

The playbook of occupiers is always the same. Yesterday, from this very podium, Mr. Erdoğan preached to the world on peace and accountability. He pointed the finger at others for crimes that Türkiye itself commits every single day. That is selective sensitivity and hypocrisy of the highest form. Illegality cannot yield legality. Illegality stemming from the use of force cannot be recognized, no matter who the perpetrator is, no matter who the victim is.

Politicians are judged not by their words but by their actions. It is what distinguishes politicians from leaders. Cyprus has proven time and time again that it is a reliable and responsible actor — a country that not only talks the talk but also walks the walk of responsibility.

My call to Mr. Erdoğan is to join that path of responsibility and to end the occupation through negotiations for a comprehensive settlement that will reunify Cyprus in a bizonal, bicommunal federation with political equality, always in line with Security Council resolutions and European Union law, values and principles. This is the only way. Therefore, let me repeat: the call for responsibility is the loudest for my own country. I am ready for this moment of responsibility, ready to deliver on the call of history to reunify Cyprus and reunify my people — Greek Cypriots, Turkish Cypriots, Maronites, Armenians and Latins.

We stand at the brink of a precipice. While the impulse may be to shrink away from the immense responsibility that we inherited from the visionaries who stood here 80 years ago, now is a moment for us to assume our responsibility, collectively and individually, as States. Rest assured that my country, Cyprus, will continue to do its part by being responsible and by being an advocate for responsibility for the good of humanity and for our peoples.

The Acting President: On behalf of the Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Cyprus for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Nikos Christodoulides, President of the Republic of Cyprus, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Alexander Stubb, President of the Republic of Finland

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Finland.

Mr. Alexander Stubb, President of the Republic of Finland, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Alexander Stubb, President of the Republic of Finland, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Stubb: In its simplest form, foreign policy is really about three things: values, interests and power. I come from a relatively small country, Finland. Our toolkit is mainly about two of those three things: values and interests. Power, hard or soft, is usually the luxury of bigger players. The power of a smaller country arises from its capacity to cooperate with others. Smart diplomacy gives a smaller player at least relative influence.

The United Nations is, of course, a case in point. Big players have power through their permanent membership in the Security Council. But we, the smaller players, can influence the ebb and flow of international relations by being active in the corridors of diplomacy. Most of the speeches that we have heard here today have highlighted that the world order, balance and dynamics are changing, much like they did after the Second World War, when the United Nations was founded.

I actually think that the post-cold war order is over, but we do not know what the new order is going to look like. It will take at least five to ten years for things to settle. My message to the Assembly today is that, regardless of size, each and every Member State of the United Nations has agency — a say in how the new world order will look. It is important that we all use this power wisely and responsibly. I fully appreciate that our interests differ, depending on our geographical location, history, state of development or culture. But fundamental values are something we should all share. We have collectively defined some of the most essential of them in the Charter of the United Nations.

Today, I want to do two things: first, analyse where we are; and secondly, give my proposals on what we might want to do together. To understand what is currently happening in the world, I would like to highlight three different yet related developments.

First, it seems to me that there is a growing tension between multilateralism, in other words, an order based on the rule of law, and those who speak the language of multipolarity or transactionalism — the difference between multilateralism and multipolarity. I can understand the temptation and the rationale of the proponents of multipolarity and transactionalism. But can they solve the world's biggest challenges, such as climate change or sustainable development?

Today, I see many States, both big and small, pursuing transactional or multivectoral foreign policies. In essence, their aim is to diversify their relations with multiple actors rather than align with any particular bloc. This can be opportunistic, but it may also be justified and reasonable. This depends on practical choices made. A transactional or multivectoral foreign policy is dominated by interests. Interests drive the practical choices of States, and this is entirely legitimate. This kind of foreign policy is based on a realistic understanding of power. Power defines the limits of what is possible for each State. However, values should actually underpin everything we do. Even a transactional or multivectoral foreign policy should rest on a core of fundamental values. Without them, foreign policy will ultimately run into a wall. If one sets aside values for the unhindered pursuit of power and interests, one will eventually find the very same problems one wanted to overlook.

Secondly, the balance of power in the new world order is shifting towards the South and the East. Many countries, especially in Africa, Asia and Latin America, are becoming or have become key players in determining the direction of the new world order. Simply put, they have both agency and power. They are not only expanding their economic force, but their demographic growth is inexorable. This will also turn them into a political and cultural force. It will yield them both hard power and soft power, and they will use it to promote their interests, as they should.

The 193 members of the United Nations do not have to agree on every minute detail of values, but we have to have a common understanding of the fundamentals. They include the sovereignty and territorial integrity of States, the prohibition of the use of force and respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms. These values are the building blocks of who we are and what we stand for as the United Nations. The broad international community has an overwhelming interest in upholding them. Let me be clear. Russia has no right to continue its aggression against Ukraine. Israel has no right

to violate international law in Palestine. States have no right to use Sudanese or Congolese territories to fight proxy wars for their economic or strategic self-interests. I urge us all to heed this message of the international community and act accordingly. War is always a failure of humanity. It is a collective failure of our fundamental values. It is a failure of us as human beings.

Thirdly, I would like to say a few words about the state of the United Nations, the institution where we are. The United Nations was created to maintain and promote peace, stability, development and friendly relations among nations. In order to achieve this, a balance between the three elements was required. Power, at the highest level, was represented by the Security Council. The interests of the wider membership were reconciled here in the General Assembly, and the values were enshrined in the Charter and consolidated as rules of international law.

Unfortunately, today, the United Nations is struggling to fulfil its central promise of delivering peace and stability. We can always blame each other, but at the end of the day, it is a collective decision. Countries have increasingly taken the liberty of breaking the rules of international law, using force against other peoples' territories and suppressing other nations. The United Nations of today does not sufficiently reflect the realities of the balance of power. Too often, it fails to serve as a forum for the coordination of interests. The values at its core are too often not respected in good faith. We all want the freedom to make choices and the possibility to influence the world around us. Today, many countries are seeking answers in multipolarity or transactionalism. If the United Nations fails to deliver, this trend will accelerate.

Let me therefore sum this up in terms of the three pillars — values, interests and power. Our values can divide us. Fundamentally, however, they should unite us around the basic principles of humanity, the rule of law and the prohibition of aggression. Our interests differ, and it is only right that we promote them. However, our choices have consequences. Opportunism will eventually be forced to confront the problems it tried to ignore. Power will constantly seek a new balance. We must adapt to change. Nevertheless, we should not allow the rise of hard power to blind us. The power of legitimacy, integrity and rules will remain strong.

Let me get to my second part — moving from the situation to possible solutions or things that we could do together. Never before in history has humankind had such means and innovations at its disposal to solve the world's most pressing problems. However, the current direction is wrong in so many ways. There are more wars than at any time since the Second World War. The world is becoming increasingly divided, as are our societies. Measures to address climate change and sustainable development are lagging behind. In different parts of the world, we are witnessing immense civilian suffering and blatant disrespect for humanitarian principles. For me as a Finn, Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine not only reminds me of our past but is also directly linked to the security of the part of the world where I live.

On the one hand, there is aggression, total disregard for civilian life and attempts to undermine the fundamental principles on which the international order is based. On the other hand, there stands a bastion of freedom, defending its right to exist and to make its own choices. The battle for what consequences we will draw from this aggression is not yet over. Recently, there has been a serious attempt at diplomatic solutions to the war, at the initiative of the United States. There are no perfect solutions to wars. At the same time, we know that any decisions made in these matters will have far-reaching consequences in Ukraine and beyond. There can hardly be a stronger unifying interest among the Organization's broad membership than our opposition to wars of conquest. Aggression must not be rewarded. Accountability for the most serious international crimes must be pursued.

In the Middle East, civilians in Gaza are experiencing immense suffering. The deepening humanitarian crisis has reached unbearable levels and represents a failure of the international system. At the same time, Hamas continues to hold the hostages it has taken, and many have already lost their lives. An immediate ceasefire is needed in Gaza. That has been reiterated from this podium many times today and yesterday. Humanitarian aid must be granted safe and unhindered access. The hostages must be released. I commend the efforts led by France and Saudi Arabia to advance the two-State solution. The negotiations must meet Israeli and Palestinian security needs, as well as the Palestinian right to self-determination and its legitimate aspiration for statehood and sovereignty. The occupation that began in 1967 must end, and all permanent-status issues must be resolved. Correspondingly, countries that have not recognized Israel must do so. At the same time, the international community must support and strengthen the Palestinian Authority for it to govern the entire Palestinian territory effectively. This is the only viable option for achieving a two-State solution. A stable Palestine will also significantly benefit the security of Israel.

In many other parts of the world, conflicts are raging, causing immense suffering locally, instability regionally and reverberations globally. We have witnessed particularly brutal violence in the Sudan, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Haiti, Myanmar and Mali, among others. Civilian populations continue to face famine and displacement on a large scale. Sometimes I feel that we end up looking only at conflicts that are near to us, but I think that the job of the United Nations is to look at all of them with equal determination.

I praise all those who, in good faith, continue to work for peace, despite the daunting task. In June, a peace agreement was reached for the conflict in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo. The true test, as with all peace agreements, lies in its implementation. Will it hold? There is a humanitarian crisis of alarming proportions that compels all of us to respond. Peace processes should not be transactional. They must be guided by international law. All countries and stakeholders in the region must be engaged and committed to achieving sustainable peace. The presence and involvement of the United Nations is essential.

I would also like to stress the crucial work carried out by journalists amid conflicts and in other difficult circumstances. Attacks on members of the media are unacceptable. Media freedom is the basis of democracy. It is a prerequisite for an open society. The ability of the press to carry out its work is important for all of us.

The composition of the United Nations still largely reflects the world of 1945. As the world has changed drastically, so must the decision-making at the United Nations. Last year in this very Hall, I argued for a reformed Security Council, a Council where currently underrepresented regions would have a stronger voice through permanent seats at the table.

The number of permanent members of the Security Council must be increased. At the very least, there should be two new seats for Asia, two for Africa and one for Latin America. I think I am going to say this every year because it is the only place where I get applause. No single State should have the veto power and, if a member of the Security Council violates the Charter, its voting rights should be suspended.

I believe that these changes at the top of the United Nations are necessary in order to maintain the Organization’s central role in international relations. At the same time, a more comprehensive reform of the United Nations is needed. I commend the Secretary-General for his UN80 Initiative and encourage him to take bold and ambitious action. Finland strongly supports the United Nations and wants it to succeed. Therefore, we stress the need for true reform to enhance the Organization’s credibility, relevance and efficiency. This will ensure that the United Nations can act.

The United Nations needs to focus its efforts on its most important goals: ending and preventing wars, protecting human rights and acting as a catalyst for sustainable development. Furthermore, we need to get the United Nations back into peace mediation. I would argue that one of the reasons why we have so many wars right now is that the United Nations is absent from peace mediation. No other organization can offer legitimacy comparable to that of the United Nations. If the United Nations is absent, conflicts are not resolved, which is not in our common interest. The United Nations is needed as a mediator, and the Member States should support it in this endeavour.

Finally, Finland is strongly engaged in the work of the United Nations and will remain so. Therefore, we are also standing for election to the Security Council for the 2029–2030 term. Should we be elected, Finland pledges to be a principled and pragmatic partner for peace. We are principled in our commitment to international law, with the Charter at its core. We are pragmatic in seeking solutions that truly advance international peace and security, recognizing that progress is often incremental.

At the outset of my speech, I said that each and every one of us has agency — a say in what the new world order will look like. We want to be able to make our own choices and have an impact on the world around us. Nelson Mandela saw truth and reconciliation as the only hope for nations that are bitterly divided. The same applies to relations between States. We should learn from history, but always look to the future, bearing in mind that our decisions will shape it.

The Acting President: On behalf of the Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Finland for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Alexander Stubb, President of the Republic of Finland, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Julius Maada Bio, President of the Republic of Sierra Leone

The Acting President: The General Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Sierra Leone.

Mr. Julius Maada Bio, President of the Republic of Sierra Leone, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Julius Maada Bio, President of the Republic of Sierra Leone, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Bio: I congratulate Ms. Annalena Baerbock on her election as President of the General Assembly at its eightieth session to lead this historic session. I thank her predecessor, Mr. Philemon Yang, for his distinguished leadership during the seventy-ninth session. I commend Secretary-General António Guterres for his steadfast commitment to the ideals of the United Nations during these increasingly turbulent times.

It is both an honour and a solemn responsibility to address the Assembly at the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations. This session of the Assembly is not just ceremonial; it is a call for the world's conscience to act with unity, determination and vision. Our theme — "Better together: 80 years and more for peace, development and human rights" — both celebrates and summons. It reminds us that cooperation delivers progress. It also demands that we reimagine multilateralism so that peace, dignity and equality are not promises on paper but realities in the lives of people. This anniversary is not a time for complacency, but for courageous renewal. Today, we face deepening inequalities, climate crises, geopolitical fragmentation, technological disruptions and entrenched conflicts.

No nation can meet these challenges alone. We need bold multilateralism and a United Nations that is not only reformed but reinvigorated. The United Nations must be more than a meeting place; it must be a working place — for people, for peace and for our planet.

Sierra Leone is a small State that has relied heavily on the Charter of the United Nations and now helps to uphold it. We speak with independence and conviction because we have lived the cost of its absence. I also serve as Chair of the Authority of Heads of State and Government of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) and Coordinator of the African Union Committee of Ten Heads of State and Government on Security Council Reform. For both myself and the people of Sierra Leone, these roles are not just titles; they are responsibilities. They reflect Sierra Leone's conviction that principled multilateralism is the surest defence of law, equity and peace.

Since 1945, the Charter's promises of sovereign equality, non-aggression and human dignity have been the bedrock for small States like ours. In 1961, when Sierra Leone first addressed the Assembly (see A/PV.1018), our founding Prime Minister, Sir Milton Margai, pledged that our voice would be independent and principled, guided not by bitterness but by conviction. That pledge remains our compass.

We stand for justice and equality. We uphold the right of all peoples to self-determination. We speak truth to power and act in defence of humanity and the rule of law. Small States are not inherently small. Our sovereignty is equal, and our responsibilities are the same. Leadership is not the loudest voice in the room; it is the clearest voice for justice.

Our current term on the Security Council has deepened these convictions. Guided by the Charter, we have championed peace through dialogue, upheld international law and promoted prevention as the first duty of collective security. We have supported efforts to stabilize the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, de-escalated tensions in the Middle East and supported political transitions in Lebanon and Syria for peace and stability.

We have also seen the Security Council's limits — its paralysis in the face of grave human suffering. Nowhere has this failure been more heart-wrenching than in Gaza. A preventable genocide was not prevented. Mass starvation that could have been avoided was not avoided. A broadly supported two-State solution has been obstructed by division and inaction. We therefore welcome all Member States that have recently announced their long-overdue recognition of the State of Palestine.

Yet much more remains to be done: we must bring an end to the war and ensure the release of all hostages and prisoners. Sierra Leone has not wavered. We have spoken with independence, voted with principle and pressed for urgent action to end atrocities and revive hope. We say again: Ceasefire now in Gaza. Ceasefire now in the Sudan. Ceasefire now in Ukraine. These are not just slogans; they are calls to conscience, calls to action. In fact, they are echoes of the Organization's founding pledge to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war. A veto should never be a verdict against humanity.

Across the world, the authority and legitimacy of the United Nations are being tested: selective adherence to international law, disregard for Security Council and General Assembly resolutions, deprivation of funding, attacks on peacekeepers and humanitarian workers, disinformation that corrodes trust and overreliance on unilateral action.

For countries like Sierra Leone, this is not an abstract debate. We know what a working United Nations means. At our darkest hour, during one of the most brutal civil wars in modern history, the United Nations stood by our side. The United Nations

Observer Mission in Sierra Leone — one of the largest peacekeeping operations of its time — helped disarm more than 75,000 combatants, restore civilian governance and support democratic elections. The Special Court for Sierra Leone and the Truth and Reconciliation Commission, both backed by the United Nations, ensured justice and reconciliation.

When the United Nations Integrated Peacebuilding Office in Sierra Leone closed in 2014, it signalled something rare in our world — a successful transition from war to peace. We saw blue helmets on our streets. We saw ballot papers returned to citizens' hands. We saw our nation breathe again.

When the United Nations works, lives are saved. When it fails, lives are lost. We must ensure that the United Nations delivers for all. To do so, we must respect and implement United Nations decisions, protect those who serve under the United Nations flag, invest in prevention and peacebuilding and reform the Security Council so that its authority and legitimacy match today's world.

The United Nations cannot protect vulnerable people if it cannot protect its own authority. As a nation, Sierra Leone does its part and contributes troops to peacekeeping missions. We serve as an elected member of the Security Council and offer our experience in peacebuilding to the world. Sierra Leone's story is proof that multilateral solidarity works when it is grounded in trust, mutual respect and genuine investment in national ownership.

Peace is inseparable from development. In Sierra Leone, our medium-term national development plan, aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals and Agenda 2063 of the African Union, prioritizes people-centred growth. We are transforming our agricultural sector to ensure food security. We are investing in a digital economy that fosters inclusion and innovation. We are deepening investments in human capital development through our Free Quality School Education initiative and in healthcare, in particular maternal and child health.

We are expanding renewable energy to support industrialization and climate resilience. Climate change is an existential threat to Sierra Leone. Our greenhouse gas emissions are negligible, yet our people and our wide coast bear the cost through erosion, flooding and pressure on food systems and fisheries.

We have mainstreamed climate adaptation and strengthened disaster preparedness. In fulfilment of the commitment made at the third United Nations Ocean Conference, Sierra Leone has ratified the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction (BBNJ). As the sixtieth State to deposit its instrument of ratification, Sierra Leone is proud of the collective endeavour to trigger the entry into force of the BBNJ, a historic milestone for multilateralism and the collective stewardship of our ocean commons. We urge all countries to do the same so that the high seas and the areas beyond national jurisdiction are governed for the common good.

Climate justice is not charity. It is a legal and moral responsibility. If the poorest are left to pay the highest climate price, there is no justice. Developed nations must honour their commitments — $100 billion a year in climate financing, technology transfer and capacity-building. We welcome the advisory opinion of the International Court of Justice on climate change, affirming States' obligations to prevent environmental harm and to protect future generations. In that spirit, Sierra Leone is proud to present the candidature of Mr. Charles Chernor Jalloh, a distinguished jurist and tireless advocate for the rule of law, to the International Court of Justice. We respectfully solicit the support of all Member States in the elections on 12 November.

As Chair of the ECOWAS Authority of Heads of State and Government, I proudly note our Community's fiftieth anniversary. For five decades, ECOWAS has embodied regional integration and collective security, often acting decisively when others hesitated. ECOWAS moved early in Sierra Leone's peace process, before and alongside the United Nations, to end our civil war. It has done so in Liberia, the Gambia and elsewhere to defend democracy and stabilize the region. These are African solutions to African challenges, open to global partnerships anchored in regional legitimacy and trust. Partnership with Africa must move from promise to practice.

As Chair of the ECOWAS Authority, I recently embarked on a regional tour, including a second visit in two years to Burkina Faso. This was to demonstrate solidarity and build trust between ECOWAS member States and the Confederation of Sahel States. I commend the leadership of Burkina Faso for its willingness to engage, and I look forward to continuing dialogue with the leadership of both Mali and the Niger.

In my role as Chair of the ECOWAS Authority, I have placed emphasis on advancing and safeguarding democratic governance, with a strong commitment to upholding constitutional order and reflecting the will of the people; countering terrorism and strengthening our regional security architecture, including the operationalization of the ECOWAS Standby Force and the implementation of counter-terrorism strategies; enhancing economic integration by promoting trade liberalization, developing cross-border infrastructure and advancing towards a common ECOWAS currency; and strengthening the credibility of institutions through reforms that promote transparency, efficiency and citizen-focused services.

We urge the United Nations to deepen its partnership with ECOWAS and other African regional mechanisms in the spirit of Chapter VIII of the Charter of the United Nations. Africa is not a problem to be solved. Africa is a partner to be empowered.

During Sierra Leone's tenure as an elected member of the Security Council for 2024–2025, we have highlighted the urgent security challenges in West Africa and the Sahel, where terrorism and violent extremism transcend borders and destabilize the entire region. However, Africa's lack of permanent representation continues to hinder the Council's ability to act decisively and contextually. We have advocated a comprehensive approach to counter-terrorism in the Sahel, linking security with development, governance reforms and regional cooperation, and strengthening the United Nations–African Union–ECOWAS partnership. Too often, however, the Council's response has been hindered by narrow geopolitical interests, delaying action that could have saved lives. Our experience confirms a clear truth: lasting peace requires inclusivity, ownership and legitimacy. The Council's structural imbalance undermines its credibility and must be addressed to safeguard collective security.

In my capacity as Coordinator of the African Union Committee of Ten Heads of State and Government on United Nations Security Council Reform, I speak on behalf of a continent that remains excluded from permanent representation on the Council. Africa, home to 1.4 billion people and the largest regional bloc in the United Nations, still has no permanent seat. This is unjust and untenable. It undermines the credibility of the Council and the legitimacy of its decisions.

The common African position, as expressed in the Ezulwini Consensus and the Sirte Declaration, calls for at least two permanent seats for Africa, with full rights and prerogatives, including the veto, if retained, and two additional non-permanent seats. This is not a request. It is a demand for equity. It is a test of the Organization's commitment to fairness and its own Charter. During our Security Council presidency in August 2024, we gave this issue unprecedented prominence. As we mark the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations and the twentieth anniversary of the Ezulwini Consensus and the Sirte Declaration, let this be the moment when the international

community answers Africa’s call. Let us not pass on to the next generation a Security Council reform that fails to reflect the world as it is today.

The United Nations at 80 must look forward. Sierra Leone, committed to principled multilateralism, stands ready to speak with independence and conviction and to work for justice and solidarity and the dignity of all peoples.

Let this anniversary be a turning point — measured not in the many speeches we make here, but in service; not in declarations, but in delivery. Let us build a United Nations more representative, more responsive and more resilient. The world does not need a louder United Nations. It requires a braver United Nations. Now is the time to make the United Nations work for all. Together let us forge a future of peace, shared prosperity and human dignity for in unity, we are not only better — we are stronger.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Sierra Leone for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Julius Maada Bio, President of the Republic of Sierra Leone, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: We have heard the last speaker in the general debate for this meeting. The next plenary meeting to continue with the general debate will begin at 3 p.m.

The meeting rose at 2.30 p.m.